

BOOK NINE
DUPLICITOUS DEVILS

9
Devil
IN THE WATERS

KT MORRISON

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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All characters are over the age of eighteen.

DUPLICITOUS DEVILS

A Devil In The Waters Novella

Book 9

26,000 words

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5G

The fine charcoal jacket fit Josh better than he expected. Though the pant legs were too long and bunched around his feet, the suit looked better on him than anything in his closet. Than anything he'd ever worn in the past.

Every day at his executive-level desk he donned a suit and tie, and had done so for years since college. And yet the difference between this suit and his others was the same as when he graduated from post-college business casual to his current wardrobe. An undeniable improvement to his masculinity showed in the suit's tailored fit—the way it rested on his shoulders, the way it narrowed at the waist. It highlighted his best features. And somehow, having those attributes highlighted revealed something else, maybe only to him: there were no unfortunate features. Nothing about his face or his body that he needed to conceal. For so long he'd operated under the assumption that he should blend into the background, become wallpaper; that if he attracted attention it would always be the wrong kind of attention. That girls would laugh at him and guys would want to punch his face in—both for the same reason: they could see through him, through his appearance, know that it was a lie and want to punish him for the attempted deception. They would humiliate him publicly for a sin worse than vanity. They would punish him for the transgression of pretense. Somehow the way he perceived himself never aligned with the way others saw him. His friendships were profound and long-lasting, the love from his wife was pure and unadulterated and stronger than any other. Those who worked for him showed gratitude and respect. And yet the core of his psyche seemed brittle or fragile, and not a reflection of the fondness and

support all those in his orbit showed him. It had never been clearer that Josh Waters was his own worst enemy.

Eyes still on his reflection, he smiled, still switching side to side, still admiring himself. How did the cut of a suit illuminate such a cloudy and remote territory in his psyche's landscape?

From behind him, Kimmy said, "You look so damn good, Josh. I mean it."

That was how.

The earnestness in Kimmy's words proved she saw what he saw. A very different way to interpret Josh Waters given the vast improvement in his appearance. The Josh Waters in the tailor's mirror stood straighter, looked fitter, presented more masculine. And he wasn't even trying. Hence, no pretense.

The tailor said to Kimmy, "He's lucky he has such a nice build. Your husband was made to show off fine clothing."

Kimmy lounged in one of two leather armchairs, a mahogany table between them, her green tea served in a fine china cup with a saucer, gently steaming. It was lunchtime on a Monday, both of them taking an extended midday break to meet in Yorkville, downtown Toronto.

“My husband needs a good suit or two,” Kimmy said to the tailor, a heavysset man named Tony, who stood expectantly between them, also wearing a tailored suit. But Tony’s jacket was off, his French cuff sleeves rolled up to the elbows, a tape measure draped around his neck, a pincushion band around his wrist, its velvet bed bristling with stainless tines tipped with fat white beads.

“Every man does,” Tony said.

That old curmudgeonly and pragmatic part of Josh made him say, “I have a closet full of good suits.”

Kimmy said, “Not like that one.”

“No,” he agreed, almost facing Kimmy now, head craned over a shoulder to regard his reflection to see if the suit looked as good from the back. It did. “Not like this one,” he muttered.

Kimmy said to Tony, “And you can definitely have it for this Friday?”

Tony lay a hairy hand over his heart. “My word you’ll have it Friday morning.”

“Josh, you’re taking it,” Kimmy said with sly finality.

He wouldn't argue. But he also didn't want to know the price. "If you say so," he said, surrendering control to his wife as he faced the mirror again and adjusted the lapels. Over his reflection's shoulder he saw Kimmy nod approval to Tony who unwound the tape measure from his neck and got to work marking adjustments on the pants with a small square of chalk.

Down on one knee at Josh's side, Tony asked what was the function on Friday that required such a fine suit. Kimmy said, "My boss is taking my husband to the Jays game."

And since that didn't seem like a suitable answer to why he would need a good—no, amazing—suit, he added: "Private box."

"Well, well, well," Tony said, running the tape measure up Josh's inseam.

"He's not just her boss, he's our friend from school," he said, then wondered when exactly it had become permissible to call Devlin a friend. "Kimmy is his lawyer."

Kimmy said, "We all went to high school together in Kingston. Devlin Stone."

Tony tilted his head. "Devlin Stone? I've fitted him many times."

“Devlin recommended you,” Kimmy said.

Of course Devlin did. It all made sense now. This surprise lunch time visit to the tony old village of Yorkville had been Kimmy’s idea. Earlier he’d wondered how they’d got an appointment with a tailor so quickly. This tailor—situated in one of Toronto’s snazziest neighborhoods, nestled into the overgrowing city in an old Victorian house, in amongst stores like Chanel and Gucci and Christian Louboutin—must have a very long line up for such personal service. Kimmy made the appointment this morning—for only a few hours later. Devlin had pull here, and obviously she’d dropped Devlin’s name.

But instead of letting it bother him, Josh enjoyed it. Sure, letting Kimmy work for Devlin Stone had its hardships, but maybe they’d all rolled that heavy rock up the hill now. Being close to Devlin Stone came with perks. Money—lots of it—trips to private Cayman villas, box seats at the Jays game, and you could jump the queue if you, say, wanted a very fine suit, very fast.

“Devlin Stone is a good man,” Tony said, shuffling around to do the other leg. “A good customer.”

“Devlin dresses very well,” Kimmy said. Josh watched her in the mirror, a grand eight-foot tall monstrosity framed in tarnished brass, and leaned against the wall.

Tony said, “Next time you come, don’t make it so urgent. I’ll fit your husband with something custom.” Tony gestured with his hand the way a

Michelin-star chef would, some sort of four-finger Mediterranean OK sign that conferred exquisiteness.

Due to the time constraints of when this suit was needed, they couldn't have something tailored. But the shop also had some off-the-rack items that could be customized. This rich, warm charcoal single-breast with a faint chalky window-pane called to him from the rack. He tried on three others but none of them compared to this one. None of the items had prices. He feared the suit might cost as much as five-grand. It was Kimmy's treat, but still, it seemed exorbitant. Now that he'd seen himself in it, there would be no dissuading him. He was going to have this suit. And he was going to wear it out on Friday night with Devlin Stone.

Josh flinched as Tony's hand slid one end of the tape measure up his inseam and knuckle-brushed his package. An uncomfortable grunt hitched in his chest, and then both he and Tony chuckled. Tony hadn't harmed him, but the contact was startling.

Kimmy had been watching. She said, "At least you know on which side he dresses."

More awkward chuckling, though Josh was unsure what that meant. He asked and Tony said, "It's an old way of asking where you keep the family jewels. Which pant leg?"

"Ah," Josh said, feeling his cheeks heat with embarrassment. Then to join in on the fun he said, "I'm a lefty."

After a small beat of quiet, Kimmy said, “Devlin’s a righty.”

The quiet after that went on and on and the heat on Josh’s cheeks grew to flames. Even his ears burned. Tony said nothing, but his eyebrows raised as he concentrated on marking the pant cuff.

Such a dumb thing for Kimmy to say. Such a salacious thing. It wasn’t even funny. And it was ripe with awful connotation. Hopefully Tony thought Kimmy just wasn’t good at making jokes or witty banter. She’d just pulled the pin on a hand grenade and let it roll to his feet, thinking everyone would laugh. But no, Tony would be thinking it wasn’t a joke. That Kimmy knew which side Devlin Stone dressed on. That this poor chump getting a suit bought for him by his wife like she was his mommy, was oblivious to the obvious fact his wife was fucking this guy Devlin Stone. He was fitting a suit for a cuckold. A dumb, blind cuckold. And, fuck, Tony fitted Devlin. Tony most likely knew how much man-meat was dressed on Devlin’s right side. It was probably a concern between tailor and well-hung client. We have to make the right leg a little looser because I tuck a fucking anaconda down it.

Kimmy sneered at him in the reflection and he could see how red his cheeks had blossomed. At least she enjoyed the joke. She looked so fucking sexy sunk in the chair, her long skinny legs crossed one over the other, wearing a black pant suit and black blouse, her expensive shoes—

The red soles. They were Louboutins. Perhaps purchased just next door. Maybe one day she’d come down here with Devlin to pick up a custom suit and she nipped next door to buy herself some expensive footwear.

His cock hardened at a furious pace. Maybe his sexy wife had lounged in that chair the same way she did now, looking like an evil fashion model, and one of the other tailors measured Devlin's inseam, and Kimmy had learned that day what "dressing" meant, and they all laughed and the tailor joked about how they would have to charge Devlin more money for the extra fabric required to accommodate his equine manhood.

Josh made an obvious gesture of checking his watch and saying, "Shoot, I really have to get going. I have to be back at the office." The worst thing right now would be for Tony to double-check that left leg inseam again and bump his hand up against a throbbing erection.

Kimmy still smiled devilishly at him, locking eyes with him in the mirror, really loving her stupid comment. The smile that spread on his face was unstoppable. As mad as he was, or as offended, or whatever the fuck he felt, he couldn't deny she'd done that to zing him. He shook his head at her reflection and she tossed her head back in silent laughter.

7G

Josh waited until they were out of the tailor's business and walking down Yorkville Avenue under the canopy shade of the street-side honey locusts before he let her have it. "Seven thousand dollars, Kimmy? Are you crazy?"

Kimmy was unbothered, amused even, chuckling to herself and not even looking at him. He stopped on the sidewalk and Kimmy slowed then turned around. She cocked her head and studied him through narrowed eyes, her brow squinched quizzically. "What, Josh? Afraid of getting what you paid for?"

The short distance between them, maybe six feet, let him see Kimmy in her full frightening glory. His wife, his best friend, his pal and confidante, was stunning. With the Louboutin heels, Kimmy stood at almost six-feet tall, long legs in narrow suit pants, a fitted suit jacket (Jesus, how much did her suits cost?) showed off her height and leanness. But her face was feminine and striking and sultry and . . . How had she transformed like this? The glossy pulled-back hair, the bright red lipstick, that fucking off the charts gorgeous face; six months ago Kimmy had been a homebody, a practical cat lady without a cat, but making daybeds for other cat ladies who spent too much money on their pets. He'd loved that Kimmy. That was the Kimmy he knew and had always known. But this Kimmy? Goddamit, who the fuck was this Kimmy, and how did a meek little mouse like Josh Waters end up with her? This was the wildest thing: the way they'd stopped and the way they stood, the way they faced each other and the way he raised his voice

all pointed to a confrontation. They had onlookers now, no one closing in, but passersby on both sides of the narrow shopping street turning head to regard the commotion. And it felt good. It felt good to be seen with her. Yeah everybody, this is my wife. Look at her. She's with me.

And she just bought me a seven-thousand dollar suit.

He acquiesced (mostly for his audience) and showed his palms and looked to the sky shaking his head at his crazy wife. He also closed the distance between them and put his arms around her. He was still outraged at the ridiculous expense, but he'd prefer for everyone watching to see how much they cared for each other and that yes, indeed, they were a couple. Shit, maybe he did need that expensive suit.

His hands smoothed her waist and gathered at the narrow of her lower back. He smiled crooked, continuing to shake his head at her in admonishment—wanting to say much more about how angry he was—and letting her know while he was mad, in public like this he would also show her how grateful he was for such an exorbitant gift.

“It’s an insane amount of money to spend, Kimmy,” he whispered.

She smirked haughtily. “I can afford it, Josh.”

“You’re supposed to say I’m worth it. And no, you can’t afford it. You’ve haven’t even been with Devlin for six weeks.”

“Do you really think Devlin is going to fire me?”

“No, but—”

“Then don’t worry about it, Josh. I’ve got it covered.”

“We’re supposed to be saving for a house. That suit is like a couple of mortgage payments.”

“I want my husband to look good,” she said. Friendly enough, but it stung a little and he couldn’t help that.

“I need an expensive suit to look good?”

“You’re going out with Devlin. Tell me you wouldn’t feel self-conscious and tell me you’re not going to feel like a million bucks when you show up in that suit.”

“I’ll feel like seven-grand,” he said.

“Sixty-seven eighty-nine, twelve,” she said, pointing out that it wasn’t quite seven-grand.

“At least you’re aware of the accounting,” he said. His mother had gone on a spending spree once when he was in high school and his father told him in anger his mother didn’t understand anything about money. Kimmy understood money. It still seemed like a terrible expense.

“I know what I’m doing, Josh,” she said and swatted his behind, smiling. He let her go, but they still faced. The amber hue to the late-summer light showed off the little bit of sun she got in Cayman, and again he was struck by how incredible Kimmy looked. They stood on brick pavers at the mouth of Old York Lane, foot traffic coming onto Yorkville from Cumberland, other men giving his wife a second look and liking what they saw. Above them on a second floor terrace the tinkling of cutlery and glass and light chatter drifted down from behind a short row of yew shrubs.

“I’m trusting you,” he said.

Kimmy took his hand and began to walk with him. “You’re going to need shoes, too,” she said.

He laughed and said, “And a haircut and a manicure. Maybe a pedicure, too. Devlin might get a look at my feet and—”

“New shoes, Josh,” she repeated. He chuckled and walked hand in hand with his beautiful wife. Eyes went to Kimmy as people passed. She stood

out, and had the allure of a celebrity. Given the location, pedestrians studied her to see if they recognized who she was from their mental rolodex of movies they'd seen.

They walked into the wide cool mouth of the Cumberland parking garage, Kimmy's heels clicking on the concrete. When he'd arrived in Yorkville he'd been lucky enough to get a parking spot on the ground floor.

"Let me drive you back to Yonge and Sheppard," he said, using the remote to unlock their Qashqai. Anyone seeing Kimmy get into his sensible vehicle would have their hopes they'd seen a Hong Kong movie star totally dashed.

Kimmy slipped in the passenger side and when he sat down, she said, "Just take me to Bloor. I'll jump out."

"That's crazy, Kimmy. I'll take you back."

"You don't have to. I'll take the subway, you get on the DVP. I'm out of your way."

"You're never out of my way," he said, turning his head toward her, feeling real genuine warm affection for her now they were in this enclosed space where it was quieter and they had no observers. Kimmy was checking herself out in the mirror on the flipped down sun visor. Satisfied, she flipped it back up and turned to face him as well. She reached over and ruffled his hair.

“You do need a haircut,” she said.

He leaned toward her, tucking his chin down while she continued to muss his hairdo. “And lose my boyish charm?”

She nudged his chin up with a knuckle so he would look at her. “You’re a man, Josh.”

He regarded her drolly. “So I need a man’s haircut?”

She snuffled light laughter through her nostrils and cupped a hand to his cheek, looking into his eyes. “Don’t ever sell yourself short. You’ve got so much going for you.”

“Tony said I could model.”

“You looked incredibly hot in that suit.”

He continued to meet her gaze, wanting to engage with her on the topic, but his mind was only one place now they were alone. “Can we talk about it?”

Kimmy frowned. “Talk about what?”

“What you said to Tony.”

Kimmy chuckled, low and breathy and mean, narrowing her eyes on his. It gave him the chills. Her hand slipped from his cheek to play at the long hair behind his ears. “Did I do something wrong?”

“Yeah, you did,” he said, a little too lightly. He was really mad about it.

“I didn’t lie.”

He clucked his tongue and held her wrist so she would stop tickling his neck with her hair play. “I get why you said it, but it’s embarrassing. What’s that guy going to think now? How can I go back there?”

“Oh Josh,” she chastised him. “I’ll pick up your suit for you on Friday.”

“It’s more than that, Kimmy. What about when Devlin goes there? Tony’s going to think he’s messing around with his lawyer.”

“Who said anything about messing around? All I said is I can tell which side he slings his dick. Anyone can tell if they look.”

“Yeah, but you’re my wife.”

“That’s why it was funny,” she said.

“It’s not funny, it’s humiliating.”

“Not humiliating, Josh. Embarrassing, maybe.”

“So you admit you embarrassed me?”

“Come on,” she said soothingly. “I wasn’t trying to embarrass you, I was playing with you.”

“I know but—”

“Don’t you like it when I tease?” Her dominant expression weakened to one of doubt.

“I do. I do, but . . .”

“I like teasing you. I like turning you on.”

Her expression wasn't haughty anymore. She was earnest. He had a beautiful wife who he was tickled to death being seen in public with. She made a lot of money. She took him to Cayman. Bought him an expensive suit. Got kinky with him. “I shouldn't be complaining, is that what you're saying?”

Now she smiled a little and ruffled his hair again. “It's just you and me playing our little game, Josh. It's just me trying to push your buttons. You like it when I do that, don't you?”

They'd even done it with Devlin in Cayman, played double entendre behind his back. “I just worry it's too obvious sometimes. Like, Devlin was on to us in Cayman.”

“Do you think Tony's a horn dog like Devlin?”

“It's not that he's got a dirty mind. It's just the simple implication of what you said could mean.”

Kimmy's expression showed she thought he was making too much of it. But he didn't think he was. She raised her eyebrows high, regarded him coolly, a slight sideways smirk. He looked at the rich application of color on her lips. An blazing red with a hint of fire in it. He didn't feel like arguing but he did want her to at the very least acknowledge she could see his viewpoint and why it might irk him.

When she only regarded him and said nothing, he said, “Don’t you see my point?”

“What do you think he thought, Josh?”

“He either thought you had checked out your boss’s package or you really suck at witty banter.”

“I don’t suck at witty banter.” She pouted and frowned.

He got it. The truth was she had checked out Devlin’s bulge. And he already knew that.

“Tony doesn’t need to know you checked out Devlin’s package.”

“I thought he might think it was funny.”

“Why would he think it’s funny?”

“He’s fitted Devlin for a suit. I’m sure he’s aware of some of Devlin’s tailoring needs. That big penis is probably a hassle for a good tailor. I half-

expected Tony to laugh and say, ‘Tell me about it.’”

Hearing her say something so aggravating roused him again. He could feel a swelling between his legs at his wife’s blunt and terrible words. She was doing it on purpose. “You’re fucking with me now.”

She smiled a hot red smile. “I’m fucking with you all the time.” Her fingers tangled in his hair.

“Why?” he said, chuckling but irritated.

“You know you love it.”

“I do?” His tone was comically incredulous.

“Sure you do. I know it turns you on. Stop fighting it.”

He gave her a point-blank What-the-fuck face? Exasperated with her, but unfortunately, yes, really fucking turned on.

Kimmy knew it, slinking over the console to get closer to him. Her eyes darted out the windshield. He’d nosed in, so their view was out the circular brick-edged opening of the upscale parking lot; the view showed nothing

but sunshine falling on leafy green tree canopy. It was like they were alone. His heart began to beat faster with the sudden realization Kimmy might be interested in having sex right now.

Her face was very close to his. She said, “Don’t fight it.”

“I’m not,” he said, looking into her eyes.

“You like to struggle,” she said, her warm palm resting on his thigh. He looked over his shoulder to make sure the coast was clear behind the Qashqai as well. No one was there.

“What are you doing?”

Kimmy smiled and her hand crept up his thigh and cupped between his legs. She explored, finding his cock in the bulge and kneading it between finger and thumb.

She made an appreciative sound, and said, “Just like I thought. You’re half hard.”

“You got your hand on it.”

“You didn’t get hard at the tailor?”

“No,” he lied.

She regarded him skeptically. Now her fingers worked at the bulge in his suit pants and found the zipper tab. He looked out the back window again.

“What are you so worried about? Tell me what Tony thinks of your bad wife?” She used both hands now to undo the zipper and work his fly open. Josh eased back in his seat to give her access, almost frightened by what she might have planned for him.

“Tell me, Josh,” she whispered. “Tell me what you’re afraid he thinks.”

His jaw muscles trembled as he sought the resolve to play along. He swallowed, eyes darting, settling back on his wife’s beautiful face. She was accepting and inviting, willing to engage in dirty talk and dirty play. She had zinged him with a live-wire blast today right in front of another man.

What would Tony think?

He said, “He thinks you’re fucking Devlin.”

“Does he?” She looked as though she didn’t think Tony thought that.

“Sure he does,” he said. “He knows you’ve checked between his legs and know . . .”

“How big his penis is?” She smiled wide and mischievous.

“Yeah,” he gasped.

“And just because I know Devlin has a really big penis, Tony thinks I’m having an affair?”

He nodded.

Kimmy worked his naked cock out of the fly and his legs kicked as the tip of her finger swiped over the tip. He was slick with pre-come. “I just need a big cock in my life? Is that it? That’s what you think of women, Josh?”

He shook his head no this time.

“So what makes you think that’s what Tony believes about me?”

As he struggled to form an answer, Kimmy leaned forward and her head dipped into his lap. His hand went to her back and rested there. Her mouth slipped over the tip of his cock and began to suck. He grunted up at the car's roof, the incredible wet pleasure of his wife's mouth and tongue driving wild whipcracks into the top of his brain and getting his whole body shuddering.

UBI PUS, IBI EVACUA

Josh trembled, too frightened to answer. But then he spoke, voice dry and cracking. “It’s because you brought it up in front of him. Brought up Devlin’s penis size. Tony thinks you’re cheating on me and you’re in that thrilling part of a relationship where you’re obsessing over your partner’s sexuality.” With the words out in the air, his brows raised high, disbelieving he’d said them. They’d come out of nowhere, bubbled up out of jagged cracks in his stony core. The idea was sick and awful, but terribly exciting. He was driven out of his mind by the idea of black betrayal, devious sex and Kimmy's desire. The words were sickness, oozing out of those subconscious cracks like pus from an abscess.

And Devlin was the injury.

If he ever wondered where the hell these ideas came from, the undeniable truth was a poisonous thorn pierced his past. It was imbedded in his psyche. And around that thorny invasion, his immune system went wild, fighting the noxious intrusion, doing its best to keep old Josh Waters alive and functioning. But the thorn remained stuck. If the thorn wasn’t removed, the pus would continue to ooze.

The whole while he struggled with this contemplation, this awful supposition, Kimmy sucked his cock and he caressed her narrow back. His thumb stroked her thin neck, his fingers wove through her pulled-back hair,

just under the braided bun. The idea Kimmy would give him a lunch time blow job was outrageous. Not the Kimmy of recent weeks, of course, but this was the same Kimmy he'd known for years—one who previously would have never thought to have sex outside of nighttime and in the safety of their own apartment with the door closed. Kimmy's core seemed to have its own cracks. And just like him, Devlin Stone was the impetus. Devlin had imbedded in Kimmy somehow. That whole thing with Kimmy running away from a threesome because she was a meek and smart student who walked into a sex trap might have lasting psychological implications his wife was working out right now. Working it out with him. Sharing in their secret miseries and enjoying a period of extreme sexuality and wanton experimentation. The idea of their mutual torture and simultaneous enjoyment had his cock surging. Already hard as a rock, he could feel it swell even wider, to the point of discomfort. His ass muscles flexed and turned his cock to steel in Kimmy's mouth.

He said, "Tony thinks Devlin's big cock is all you can think of. He thinks you're a dirty cock slut with one thing on her mind: getting reamed by Devlin Stone's giant dick. And you can't stop thinking about it and talking about it, even if it's in front of your husband."

Kimmy loved it. The tight ring of her lips squeezed around his shaft bobbed up and down with sweet liquid ease. But her mouth slipped off him, making his knees rise, and she backhanded saliva from her pouted lips. There was a wildness in her eyes. "You have to fuck me, Josh," she whispered before her mouth went over his. Her kiss was wet and sloppy, her lips full and engorged from sucking his cock.

His kiss pulled back, arms going around her as she kneeled at his side on the passenger seat. "Where?"

Kimmy looked desperate, head spinning, looking out the back window and the sides. “Come on in the back.”

Kimmy went first, squeezing through the front seats. As she removed her suit jacket back there, he did the same in the driver’s seat. With his jacket off and his tie unthreaded, he scrambled between the seats to join her. Someone passed by the trunk and he froze. Kimmy knew why he did and she ducked down. Josh pretended to sort through packages in the backseat until the coast was clear. Then he got into the back, climbed over Kimmy, and put his lips on hers. Her nails scratched his back as they kissed and he humped his cock between her legs.

“Don’t dirty my pants,” she gasped, pushing him back, fingers working furiously now to undo the top button. She got them unzipped, kicked off her heels, and shimmied the pants down her long legs. He kissed her stomach and her thighs as she did. With the pants off, Kimmy was bare from the waist down except for a pair of sexy flower-embroidered panties. Not the panties a wife would wear to work. The panties a woman wore when she thought she might get lucky. They were a rosy pink, the side straps were doubled—two sexy lines of rosy cord sweeping over her hips on both sides, a spray of summer flowers framing the shape of her crotch. The gusset was satin, but stopped low, the fabric above a screen of see-through pink that showed the skin right above her pussy. His heart thudded at the sight and he knew right away what to say.

“You wore those for Devlin?”

Kimmy smiled devilishly, eyeing him while unbuttoning the silk black dress shirt she wore, button by button, revealing her taut, toned midsection. She ran her tongue over her wet lower lip and said, “They’re his favorite.”

“Oh fuck, Kimmy,” Josh gasped, feeling a racy thrill swoop through his chest that reminded him of the rollercoaster at Canada’s Wonderland. “You wore them for him?”

“Take them off, Josh. Take off Devlin’s favorites.”

Josh lowered his lips to kiss Kimmy below her navel. His fingers slipped under the panties’ waistband and slid them downward. Kimmy writhed below him. As he slid the panties off, his kisses traveled her thighs to her knees. He held up her panties on one finger. “You wouldn’t wear these for your husband.”

Kimmy shook her head no, eyes looking up at him from under her brows and the glossy fringe of her jet-black bangs. Her knees parted and exposed her pussy to him. Even in the low light, he could see the shine on her petals.

And Kimmy wanted a cock so bad, before he even had the chance to lower his mouth to suckle her dew—which was his whole-hearted intention—she was flipping over. Sex face to face would have proved awkward in the cabin of the Qashqai, but it was the perfect situation to take Kimmy from the back. With her eager rump pressed toward him, his wife’s black-clad back slinking snake-like, he worked open his belt. His phone rang. He got the belt undone and shoved a hand in his pocket to retrieve his phone. “Shit,” he hissed. It was Samara, calling from work. He let it go unanswered and tossed his phone onto the driver’s seat, returning his attention to his horny wife.

Kimmy said, “What’s taking so long?” Still swaying her rump at him.

“Devlin gets right to it, huh?”

“He doesn’t mess around. He knows what he wants, and he takes it.”

Josh swatted her bottom, and Kimmy hissed. A blushing handprint rose on her ass like a mirage. What the hell was happening to their sex-life? What the hell was happening to their everyday life? Since Devlin came along, only good things had come their way. He’d let a patina form on the surface of his hurt, an armor against further hurt. But it had left him sour and unforgiving, and the victim of his own roiling resentment. Kimmy had polished his surface, brought back its shine, let him glow like brand new copper revealed to the sun. It exposed him to new hurt, but he was a bigger boy now and he had Kimmy at his side, and this new shining surface was thirsty for pleasure.

With his pants falling to his knees, he curled over Kimmy and pushed his stony rod into his wife. He slipped into her soft, wet interior with ease. He was hard, and she was swollen and wet and eager to receive him. He whispered in her ear, “Where do you guys meet?”

Kimmy moaned a tremulous sound, aroused out of her mind by their terrifying dirty talk. “His apartment. We meet at lunch every day.”

“God, that’s so real,” he moaned, his mind rolling backward like a heavy cart pushed uphill by an inattentive driver. It was so real. Devlin had an

apartment near the office. A fuck shack. Kimmy could go there and meet with Devlin and cheat on her husband. He could imagine Kimmy laid out satisfied and big-dick broken, naked on Devlin's bed amidst a mountain range of tangled, semen-soaked white cotton.

"You're getting second best today. You're fucking your husband at lunch."

"Mm," she moaned, hips and rump gyrating against his steady thrusting. "It'll make tomorrow more exciting."

"Do you even eat, or do you just fuck him?"

"Both. Sometimes just fuck. And we do other things, too."

"Like what?" His voice had tightened. This line of fantasy was running a slippery line along his most thrilling trail.

"He ties me up. He fucks me blindfolded. He eats my pussy so good, and oh, I love when he comes in my mouth."

"Jesus, Kimmy," he groaned, mind blotting out and his cock flexing inside his wife. Kimmy felt it and moaned with renewed excitement.

“It’s my favorite part of the day. I can’t wait to get into his bed and feel his hands on me, feel his body against mine—”

Josh grunted and shuddered, his stroke pistoning quicker and more urgently. His scalp tightened as his wife tempted him with darker fantasies than he could have expected.

And Kimmy loved the harder fucking. She broke off her dirty talk and made squeaks and grunts as he fucked her like he wanted to punish her. And in the back of his mind, this was the way Devlin fucked her. Like a pro. Like a man. He pictured Kimmy now through Devlin’s eyes. Her profile with her eyes closed, her perfect hair pulled back to reveal her flawless porcelain face; the narrow, lithe body, the long-fingered hands clutching the seat back; the exposed ass, his cock going in and out of her pussy; her little star point winking every time he pushed his cock deep inside her.

His hand stroked up the silk shirt and squeezed her skinny neck, holding her in place so he could pound his wife’s pussy thinking of another man doing it, thinking of the sounds she made right now being provoked at the thrusting of Devlin’s enormous cock. He wanted more from her. Needed more.

“Does he come inside you when he fucks you?” He grunted the question like an animal, his neck bulging, his jaw clamped down like a vise. “Do you beg him to come inside you?”

“He comes so deep inside me, Josh. He tilts my pelvis in this crazy way, and I can feel his cock head like it’s in my stomach, and it flexes, and he

roars, Josh, and I can feel his come jetting inside me—”

Now it was Josh roaring, letting loose the way he imagined Devlin would if he fucked Kimmy. And Kimmy wailed with excitement and pleasure and he could feel her fingers mashing at the underside of their union, his wife wringing on her own clit, trying to bring an orgasm. He bucked inside her, thinking how shallow he would be compared to Devlin Stone—and riding that sick thrill as he orgasmed stretched the enjoyment out for a full minute as his cock continued to twitch and jerk and pulse inside his wife. Kimmy mewled like a cat and twisted with his cock buried inside her, her face contorted as she came and he watched her closed-eye beauty, knowing behind those eyes—as much as he hated it—Kimmy was thinking of Devlin right now. It tickled his heart and his cock at the same time. Kimmy had seen Devlin’s big, flaccid horse dick on the beach in Cayman and she could play that little movie-memory behind her eyes as she came. It was okay. It was fine with him. They were doing this together.

His whole body jolted as he pulled his sensitive cock out of her and the shuddering whimper he emitted got them both chuckling. Kimmy smiled now, eyes still closed, her rump pushed out to him and her fingers still rolling against her clitoris. He sat aside of her on the bench, panting and watching his stomach heave in and out. What a crazy day. At breakfast she’d told him to meet her for lunch downtown and he said sure and asked her why and she said you should get a new suit. He’d groaned and complained and she’d persisted and he’d shown up. Next thing, Kimmy’s buying him a seven-thousand dollar suit, she’s zinging him with sexual innuendo meant for his pleasure, the tailor is saying how his body was meant to show off good clothing, and then in the car his wife goes down on him, begs him to fuck her, and then tells him a dirty story so lubricious his head shot off to Mars when he came.

His panting became chuckling, and he spanked Kimmy's ass. It was right next to him, pushing into his side of the car. She laughed and moaned and gradually sank to rest on her side.

"I'm going to need some napkins, Josh," she said, amusement and lust in her voice.

"Sure thing," he said, breathless, heaving up to squeeze between the seats and click open the glove box. He grabbed a wad of saved fast food napkins and his phone, and hauled his exhausted ass back into the rear with Kimmy. He took two napkins for himself and then gave the remaining wad to Kimmy. She pulled off a few and tucked them between her legs, rolling toward him so she could sit on her butt.

Her head lolled his way and when their eyes met, they both laughed out loud. Kimmy's hand left the wadded napkins bunched at her crotch and took his hand. He scissored her fingers between his.

"You made me feel like a million bucks today," he said.

"You didn't do too bad yourself," she said, which he took to mean she enjoyed the surprise midday car sex.

He sighed with great exaggerated content and tilted his phone toward him. Somewhere during his powerful orgasm, he'd been aware a text had chimed following the missed phone call.

“Shit,” he sighed, reading the screen.

A text from Samara.

Samara: Where are you? You better get back here. Harmeet is looking for you

Kimmy said, “What is it?”

“Don’t know,” he said, a sinking feeling in his belly now. “Trouble at the office.”

UPDIKE

It would have been impossible to find Updike's without Devlin's explicit instruction. Devlin's careful email directions to the obscure location was a good sign that tonight's meeting with his high school bully wasn't a ruse. As much as he'd grown mentally stronger over the last month, a fourteen-year-old and frightened fraction of himself still snuck around in the dusty attic and walls of his psyche. It wasn't impossible to believe that, just as Josh had that skittish victim scurrying around his brain, Devlin's brain had its own squirrel in the attic: a fourteen-year-old sadistic tormentor. And what if Devlin couldn't prevent that nasty little tormentor from swimming to the surface when one of its old favourite foils drew near and showed vulnerability?

Updike's wasn't at all like the kind of place Josh expected to meet Devlin for a drink before the Jays game. What he expected was some ostentatious and snazzy neon city bar you'd read about in a slick Toronto magazine with lots of photographs. But the narrow doorway into Updike's was sandwiched between a hat boutique and a sushi restaurant. In the narrow brick doorway: a simple glass and aluminum door you would expect lead to a second-floor apartment above the boutique—the kind of apartment suitable for a college student.

From the subway station at Keele he'd summoned an Uber to take him into The Junction. The idea of sweating in his expensive suit drove him crazy—he'd already worried about getting made fun of in the subway—like some

teenagers would taunt him for riding public transport when his suit cost as much as a good used car. Updike's was on The Junction's main drag, Dundas Street, hidden amongst the two-story brick rows of deluxe stores and bars and restaurants. After work he drove from Ajax to park the Qashqai in Kimmy's spot in the underground lot below her office in North Toronto. He hitched a subway ride into the city. Kimmy would be home already—she was going to spend time with Hyun tonight while he was out with Devlin.

He paused at the simple door, hand on the rectangular aluminum pull, and got a good look at his reflection in the glass. He angled his head one way, then the other. Gone was the boyish head of layered hair he could brush forward or back, or leave messy on the weekends. Same haircut he'd had since high school—though there'd been tepid variations along the way. With Kimmy's encouragement, he'd gone out last night and cheated on his barber. He'd visited a salon, and showed the stylist a picture Kimmy texted him. Short back and sides, brushed back on top. Not unlike Devlin.

Past the door there was a steep, narrow staircase. At the top of the stairs the space opened up to a drinking parlor. Down one side ran a polished walnut bar, the other side interspersed with shallow, upright walnut booths, like church confessionals. The place had a distinct masculinity: cigar smoking was prominent; a mounted deer head with a wide rack posed high behind the bar; the clientele was mostly male and well-dressed; the bartenders wore dress shirts and vests, and one sported a hipster handlebar mustache; most of the art on the walls were black-and-white photos of substantial men from history.

Devlin sat at the bar, wearing a dark-colored suit, elbows on the bar's red-leather padded edge, whisky glass in hand.

Josh made his way across the stylish drinking establishment, conscious of not only his new haircut and his seven-thousand-dollar suit, but also the caramel leather wingtip brogues Kimmy bought him on Wednesday night. The brogues hadn't broken in yet, so they were stiff. If it was quiet—like it had been in the tunnel-walk into the subway station at Sheppard—the leather creaked. Fortunately the low chatter at Updike's drowned out any embarrassment, and he made it to the empty bar stool next to Devlin.

“Fancy place,” he said to Devlin, hoisting himself to sit on the red leather stool next to the guy that used to scare the shit out of him when he was younger.

Devlin wheeled on the swivel stool, expression widening with unexpected friendliness. “There's the guy— Hey, Josh.” He clapped a hand on Josh's shoulder then signaled to the bartender with the mustache. “Bourbon over here.” Then he leaned closer to Josh, saying, “We're having bourbon tonight—hope you're okay with it.”

Bourbon was what got him into this whole crazy situation. Bourbon had clouded his brain and put nasty thoughts racing through it. Bourbon provoked his worst fears and speculations and opened him to Amy's mighty powers of suggestion. “Fine by me,” he said, playing it cool.

Devlin told the bartender to pour one for both of them, then pointed to the glass of the man sitting on his other side. This man wore a steel-gray suit. His bulk filled out the chest and arms, and he wore a gold watch. Devlin said to him, “This is Josh.”

The man leaned his head forward to look past Devlin at Josh. He had crystal blue eyes and a thick brown beard, neatly trimmed. “Hey, what’s up, Josh?” His voice was deep but creaky, and his smile huge and friendly. He nodded to Josh and Josh nodded back.

Devlin said, “Josh, this is Glenn. Friend from U of T.”

Josh did the expected, “Hey, Glenn,” nodding again, doing his own friendly thing, neither of them shaking hands because of the awkward seating arrangement. The bartender returned with an unlabeled crystal bottle of amber fluid and poured a generous measure into Josh’s glass, and then Devlin’s and Glenn’s. Devlin asked the bartender for more ice, and when the bartender turned, Devlin said to Josh, “Gotta have ice in this one. Brings out the smoke. Trust me.”

Glenn leaned forward to ask Josh, “You’re at Swanson, right?”

Josh said he was and Glenn looked to Devlin then back to Josh. “Yeah, we know a couple guys there, too. You’re at that Ajax office, right?”

“Yeah. It’s like the data processing hub. Big complex.” He waited a beat as the bartender plied silver tongs to add rough chunks of frosty ice to their heavy glass tumblers, then delivered his exciting news: “Swanson is sending me to Italy next month. Part of a team, looking into breaking into the Euro market.”

Glenn said, “Oh yeah?”

Devlin raised his eyebrows like he was impressed. “What’s this about?”

Harmeet had summoned Josh from crazy midday car sex with his sexy wife in fashionable Yorkville to Harmeet’s dreary office so he could offer good news, not bad news, like Josh had feared. Josh said to Devlin, “Swanson wants a bigger bite of Europe. They already partner with Gnadennote in Berlin, but it’s kind of boutique.”

Glenn got it, nodding. “You’re not going global with boutique.”

Devlin said, “Boutique is the antithesis of global data.”

“Gnadennote has great research but their markets are too young. Swanson wants a finger in every pie,” Josh said.

Devlin laughed. “Not just the young pie.”

Glenn said, “What part of Italy?”

The telling of Josh’s practical promotion at Swanson—his inclusion in a small team of executives traveling through Europe—had been something he’d practiced and played with before tonight. This good news had been something that excited him in the approach to today’s meet-up with Devlin.

Glenn's presence had been intimidating at first, but Glenn was friendly and charming and a different kind of guy than Devlin. Josh leaned one side against the bar, taking the glass tumbler of fine bourbon and swirling it to coat the ice. "Rome. Never been before. Should be a blast."

"Rome in September should be pretty nice," Devlin said without looking over.

"Best time of year to go," Glenn agreed.

He'd anticipated his story of travel flopping. How would he expect either of these guys to care about his business trip to Europe when they both probably traveled extensively for work? It wasn't the end of the world, though—if they asked questions, he'd be prepared to answer, but offering too much now would look unsophisticated. He asked Glenn, "What do you do?"

"Lawyer," he said. "Not practicing. Work in finance now, M.Y. & Weir."

Josh brought the bourbon to his lips and breathed it in. It'd been a while since his terrible escapade with the bourbon at Tiffany's post-reunion party and he feared that the smell would turn his stomach. The bourbon at tiffany's had been a good quality, and he anticipated this one would be even better. He wasn't disappointed. It was rich and smelled like hot cherrywood, but it went down so smooth he widened his eyes with surprise. It breathed smoke on the exhale. He set the tumbler down, "That is some top shelf bourbon."

Devlin took a swig of the whisky and then made a face like there was something wrong. He peered into the glass.

Josh looked around Devlin to Glenn, saying, “You live downtown?”

“Apartment on St. Clair.”

Devlin still stared at the tumbler, but murmured, “Glenn can’t keep away from UCC. He’s still stuck in high school. This doesn’t smell right.”

Josh peered over Devlin’s hand to look in the glass. Just plain old bourbon. He said, “Mine smelled fucking fantastic.”

Glenn said his did as well, and as if to offer proof, took a hefty swig and polished the whole measure off in one gulp.

Devlin held the glass toward Josh for him to smell it. Josh leaned his face in and smelled. All he got was bourbon. Devlin rotated the glass a little and now Josh did detect a funky, earthy sort of smell. He shrugged his shoulder and looked to Devlin who looked back at him quizzically. Then Devlin offered it to Glenn, who leaned to sniff.

Glenn made a look of disgust and retreated. “Yeah, it’s body smell. What the fuck?” He rubbed his nose then regarded Devlin for a long moment

before he broke out laughing and said, “Dude, it’s your fucking finger or something. Gross. Go wash your hands, you filthy hobo.”

Devlin set the tumbler down on the bar and looked at his hands, front and then back. They were clean, the fingernails manicured. Josh scooted over and swiped up Devlin’s tumbler. He took a whiff, smelled only bourbon, and joined in taunting Devlin—but doing it carefully. “Yeah, that’s not the bourbon,” he said sarcastically, leaving it open for Glenn to launch a jibe rather than him.

Glenn took the opportunity. “Aw man, Devlin, it’s some fucking skank stripper or something. Jesus, dude, don’t hookers offer up Wet Wipes these days?”

Devlin laughed and slipped off his stool. “The skank stripper days are long gone, buddy. This ain’t college anymore.” He grabbed Glenn’s collar with both hands and squeezed. Glenn was a big bear in a nice suit and could take Devlin’s squeeze, but he hunched up his shoulders and recoiled, swiping at his suit like Devlin had left cooties. Devlin laughed and adjusted his jacket then headed toward the rear of the bar, toward the hall where Josh figured the bathrooms were.

Josh was alone now with Glenn. Glenn smiled, set his elbows down on the bar and signaled for another bourbon. Josh said, “So you guys went to U of T together?”

Glenn swiveled his chair toward Josh, mouth open like he would answer. Then he caught a look over Josh’s shoulder and his expression went to one

of masculine exuberance. Josh swiveled his stool around to see a man had mounted the steps and entered the bar, standing and adjusting his jacket as he scanned the bar, scowling. He was mean and imposing, with a ruddy face and twisted nose. Though he wore a nice suit, he looked like a working man, one who spent time outdoors, with oversized hands and gnarly knuckles. His neck was thick, his collar sloping bearlike from small cauliflower ears down to powerful shoulders.

A shimmer of recognition rose on Josh's horizon, like sunbaked asphalt.

Glenn cheeped a shrill whistle to get the man's attention and then hollered, "Johnny fucking Rumble in the house."

PARIS

After a light dinner Hyun said they should go to a karaoke place. They couldn't go to Tudor Rose in Ajax because Meyer got kicked out once and though it was just the two of them tonight, no sign of Meyer, Hyun said she was still too embarrassed, even if the incident was four years ago.

They took an Uber west to Unionville and Hyun texted in a reservation at a Chinese place called Ioho KTV where there were private karaoke rooms. The spot was in a vast suburban strip mall filled with Chinese businesses, all the sign names in English and hanzi. At night the mall was emptied but for a few dozen cars out front of the multiple restaurants. Hyun told their driver to take them around the back of the plaza where the loading bays were, a long, faceless brick wall with red metal doors. Only a single row of parking spots at the back, all filled with expensive foreign sedans and a few hot-rod Japanese sports cars. Ioho KTV didn't have a storefront, only a secret back entrance, no signage, the only indication something might be happening inside was the congregation of young Chinese people, who smoked cigarettes and vaped and laughed, standing on the asphalt below the low metal stairs that led to a landing out front of double industrial doors under a red awning. The place looked grim and impersonal.

Up the stairs and beyond the doors was a long fluorescent-lit hallway, a slick vinyl banner attached to the wall with Ioho KTV printed on it. At the end of the hall a tall, glamorous woman took their names, speaking in Chinese, smiling and gracious, then opened the plain door for them. It was a

beautiful space beyond the door, black and glossy, neon tube lighting, a busy bar all in black marble. The hostess led them down a hall, away from the bar and the noise, to a private room with the word Paris engraved on a brass plaque in swash lettering.

Once inside, the room's simplistic title became clearer: a compact square space in midnight blue, a Louis XIV couch upholstered in metallic-looking silver-blue leather, a pewter table with en console legs and engraved leaves around the belt; the tabletop was lit, a flat rectangle of soft white glow under-lighting a bottle of Patrón, two fluted shot glasses, and a board with cut lemons and a bowl of sea salt. As the hostess pulled a braided rope that opened the heavy velvet curtains lining one whole side of the room—revealing a fifty-inch television—Hyun leaned close and whispered, “I hope you don’t mind, I thought we’d have tequila.”

“I don’t mind at all,” Kimmy said, chuckling.

The hostess showed them how the microphones worked and reminded them there was no smoking, departed and left them alone. They both slung their bags onto the sofa—a canapé—tossed off their jackets and settled onto the seat, melting into the leather like they were exhausted. It had been a very long day.

Hyun was the first one sitting upright after a brief respite, eager to have a drink. Kimmy hadn’t thought of Hyun as a drinker—at least not of the harsher abv—but it was a nice surprise, a welcome one since they were two young women out for a fun night, getting to know each other better even though they’d already known each other for years. Hyun peeled the seal from around the neck of the bottle and then poured a splash into each of the shot glasses. “I wonder how the game is going,” she said.

Kimmy accepted one of the shot glasses Hyun passed, crossing one leg over the other and looking up at the black ceiling above, lit somehow with twinkling stars. “I’m not going to bug him,” she said. “Let him have fun with his new guy friends without his wife checking in on him.”

Hyun pulled the board closer, saying, “Oh, I didn’t want to know the score or anything. I don’t even follow the Jays.”

“I don’t care either,” Kimmy said. “As long as he’s having a good time.”

Hyun teased her with a lemon wedge. “That’s all I meant. And I’m glad he’s got some buddies to go out with.”

“These guys are business guys, too.”

Hyun said, “Mature.”

Kimmy crinkled her nose. “I don’t know about mature. But their interests are definitely more of the masculine kind.”

Hyun chuckled and rolled her eyes, knowing exactly what Kimmy meant. “Yeah,” she agreed. “They’re still guys.”

“They can’t help themselves.”

Now Kimmy uncrossed her legs and scooted forward to the table. She and Hyun watched each other, trying not to laugh, both of them knowing there was pressure when drinking tequila to know the order of tequila-salt-lime, but trying to be mature themselves. Hyun pinched some sea salt and sprinkled it in the thumb-hollow of her fine-boned hand. She dipped her flattened tongue to it, Kimmy following suit now, smiling, watching Hyun knock back the whole shot in one toss, then tuck a lime wedge into her mouth and pierce it with her teeth. Kimmy did the same, a little stiff and awkward, but getting more comfortable hanging out with Hyun, especially when she came out of her shell like this, ordering tequila for their private room ahead of time from the Uber. They both squinted and winced, exhaling tequila fumes, mouths twisting around but keeping their cool in front of each other.

Hyun set her shot glass on the glowing table top. “It’s nice to do it right. Meyer would always”—she shook her head, trying to remember it right—“like snort the salt, or pretend to, then bite the lime and fake tossing the tequila over his shoulder or something.”

Kimmy laughed, finding it very familiar. “Josh did that, too, back in school. From a movie or something.”

Hyun said, “But it’s you and me tonight, and we’re sophisticated.”

As Kimmy laughed—an honest, feel-good post-tequila laugh—Hyun reapplied some lip gloss, the former shine on her lips erased by the lime wedge. She said, “Do you want to go first?”

“Definitely not,” Kimmy said. “You first, more tequila, then I’ll go.”

Hyun grabbed a microphone and a tablet from the side table and started scrolling through the song library on the enormous TV, finger-swiping the tablet’s screen. “You’re not thinking of moving away though, are you?”

Kimmy scrunched her face, not sure what she meant, watching Hyun’s pretty profile as she read the screen, her face painted in flashing colors of light, her lips shining like they were wet. “What do you mean?”

“From Ajax. Those houses . . . they’re all so expensive.”

“Oh,” Kimmy said, getting it now. Before dinner tonight they’d driven around to look at some new residential developments where they were taking pre-orders. “No, we’re going to stay in the area. My dad’s like here in Unionville, Josh’s job is in Ajax, and I don’t want to move to the city. Besides, it’s expensive anywhere you go around here.”

“It’s brutal,” Hyun said, still scrolling, stopping now to type into the search bar. “I liked the second place best, not the town homes but the separate lots, the half-acre ones.”

“It won’t be for a while yet. Like maybe two years, maybe three. I just like to look around for fun.”

Hyun gasped, a soft happy sound. “Here it is,” she said, face lighting up with joy. All smiles, she activated the song, the screen transforming from a menu to pure white, then an image blossoming out of the fog: a snowy night sky, the flakes floating left-right in a strong winter wind. The music began as Hyun skipped from the couch, twirled before the television, her skirt fluttering around her. She wore a light cottony dress with fine line drawings of diamonds, thin red strokes on a white field. She fumbled with the microphone’s button, laughing at herself, getting it turned on finally.

Before she even sang the first line of the song, she realized she knew it very well. Or had at one time. Hyun sang in Korean, the first line, translating how though she says to her heart don’t go, it still goes toward you, Hyun swaying, moving her arms like an experienced performer. Kimmy broke out laughing and applauded Hyun with earnest. The song was “Something Happened to My Heart,” from “Boys Over Flowers,” a high-school K-Drama she and Hyun had bonded over back when Meyer and Hyun had just got married and they were getting to know each other.

Feeling so good and warm and happy, despite the torment she’d delivered her husband into tonight, she poured two more shots of tequila, and while Hyun sang, she performed the tequila ritual again, knocking back another shot before settling into the sofa and enjoying the show. Hyun was a beautiful girl, and so shy and kind. She was reminiscent of Geum Jan-di, the sweet but poor main character in “Boys Over Flowers,” a real innocent introduced to the exciting but tainted world of the privileged.

The longer Hyun sang, the more it seemed like the words were sang to Kimmy, Hyun performing like a real K-Pop star, selling the lyrics to the listener. Her voice was sweet and beautiful—she'd already known that, she'd heard Hyun sing before, and her singing voice was something Meyer used to like to show off—but what surprised her tonight was how well she performed. The song was heartfelt, more than a fun reminiscent song from one of their favorite TV shows. When she sang about counting memories one by one, and lamenting why her heart was the way it was, there was true emotion in Hyun's tone, a pleading, hurtful cry. But when Hyun sang the lines how the only phrase she could say was I love you, but why can't you say it to me, Kimmy's smile faltered.

A strange chill passed over her; a sinking realization all at once. Something she'd maybe intoned before but now came clearer to her, a path through the last months visible like footprints in the snow. Hyun with Kimmy's haircut, Hyun saying how she had feelings for someone else, but it was unrequited.

The smile returned to Kimmy's face, now inflamed by disbelief. No way. But it made sense. It made so much sense. She was Hyun's secret love. It was so unexpectedly lovely and touching that her eyes swelled. It made her laugh as Hyun sang the lines right on cue, going back into the chorus, how her tear ducts were broken, how she couldn't stop the tears. If she was right, then Hyun had planned this before tonight. The karaoke, the song, the ready-and-waiting bottle of Patrón to embolden her courage before she sang a love song to her crush.

Hyun's pale cheeks were blushed pink. Her eyes were shining. She swayed with the soaring music, and Kimmy admired her friend, watching the movement of her calves and her thin knees below the hem of her skirt. She could imagine the angst Hyun may have experienced dressing up tonight, wondering what she would wear, probably fearful, fretful, a sick knot in her

stomach as she braved her own anxiety and tried to break free of it so she might express a fraction of how she felt about Kimmy.

There was something alluring about it. Arousing, even. To be the subject of another's obsession or attraction, enough they wanted to offer a grand gesture from their heart, wanting to make a connection, to feel valued or maybe even loved in return. But with that came a pressure, a compulsion to react in a way that would preserve Hyun's feelings. She loved Hyun. She was a bright spot in their lives, a decent human, the mother of their beloved niece.

But as Hyun continued, singing with emotion, swaying, moving her arms in slow and graceful strokes, she couldn't help a darker fantasy opening before her from all this displayed innocence. A way to comfort her friend through inclusion. Collusion, too. Bringing in her beautiful friend, sharing some of those parts of her that scared herself, opening up how dangerously close to the sun she'd flown this summer, how close she was coming to setting her whole life in flames. She needed someone in her life to confess to. She'd sought a confidant. That was why she'd befriended, or at least rekindled, an existing friendship with Hyun. And if Hyun felt this way about Kimmy, then what would that mean of their friendship? It would mean she could probably tell Hyun everything, and Hyun would comfort her. Maybe help her find a way out of this terrible tangle she'd pulled around herself. Hyun could even help her find a way out.

And as Hyun wrapped up the song, laughing and blushing, eyes wet and teary, Kimmy called Hyun to her. Hyun flicked off the microphone and stumbled comically, slump shouldered and embarrassed. Kimmy welcomed her with a pure and open embrace, Hyun falling onto the couch and laughing and turning away, and Kimmy hugging her, laughing as well and telling her how she didn't know she could sing so well and how it was one of her favorite songs.

There was something good about giving another human you cared about the reaction they craved. A feeling of “doing good.” And in the midst of her shadowy world of doing bad, Hyun could maybe serve as a redeemer.

She could picture it now, holding Hyun’s slender and delicate body: maybe in bed, maybe a tender moment of sharing and exploration—three of them, luring Josh into her own dark world, showing her husband how sexual curiosity could ignite lust into a raging fire. Hyun was his cousin’s ex-wife, the mother of their niece.

ALLEY CATS

The cartoonish silhouette of a ragged alley cat glowed in pale green on the back of Josh's hand. It provided club security proof he was permitted in the Pink Champagne Room. Even though the sight of it caused him anxiety, he liked the way it looked below the cuff of his expensive suit.

On the second floor of the Alley Cat Hotel were the club's VIP rooms, where small groups or single individuals could get a private show from some of the Alley Cat's dancers. Full nude. Leather half moon bench seat that ran a crescent on one side of the velvet-wallpaper room, open carpeted floor space for a dancer, then a closed door opposite. Bottle service. Grey Goose tonight, served with ice and half cans of Canada Dry. Devlin sat on Josh's right with his tie loosened, Rumble on Josh's left, and Glenn on Rumble's left.

The Alley Cat Hotel was the name of the gentleman's club that took up most of the first floor and some of the second floor of the hundred-plus year-old hotel called the Sherwood Hotel. A hundred-plus years ago, when Toronto wasn't much of a city at all, just a collection of close bustling rural villages connected with street cars and serviced by a busy port and railway, the prow-shaped, five-floor Sherwood Hotel was a well-heeled traveler's mainstay. For the last thirty years it housed the Alley Cat, one of the city's prominent—and expensive—strip clubs.

A blond Russian girl named Minka danced for them in high heels. Her red camisole top lay in Glenn's lap and now she held the back of a prop chair she'd brought along, swooping her panty-clad ass in Johnny Rumble's drunken face, dancing to a remix of Doja Cat's "Kiss Me More."

Rumble spanked her ass cheek with his thick-fingered hand and Minka waved her finger no, but then took his hand and brought it back to her ass cheek and let him squeeze and coddle her. Devlin shook with laughter at Josh's side, leaning way back, one arm resting on the back of the bench, the other holding a vodka ginger in place on a thigh.

The Jays had beat the Cubs 5-3, and they'd left the private box on the second out, top of the ninth, before the traffic got too hectic. Rumble was loaded and looking for trouble. His face was ruddy and lined and his eyes bleary and dangerous looking. The thug from high school had become a thug in adult life too, now wearing an expensive suit and working as a goalie coach for a prominent Toronto hockey school. Turns out Rumble had got picked up by the Washington Capitals after the second year of university but washed out of their camp before he'd ever got his skates and goalie pads on NHL ice. It left Josh wondering what washed Rumble out. Punching out a coach or another player, maybe biting off someone's nose or excessive fighting. Who knew. Whatever it was, Josh was sure it was violent and fit in line with Johnny Rumble's noxious personality.

Johnny Rumble was Devlin's stated reason for visiting the Alley Cat, teasing Rumble in the limo, leaving the Rogers Centre saying, "Johnny's had his cock in a cage and now it's finally free. We're going to take it out on the town tonight and show it a good time." Johnny's wife had signed their divorce papers, and what Devlin made sound like a contentious divorce was now at last settled. Johnny only grumbled and ground his teeth, scowling, looking agitated. But he didn't turn down the offer to go to the Alley Cat—in fact, it might have been the only thing that saved Glenn and

Devlin from a fist fight. Josh cowered in the limo, pushed into the corner, hoping and trusting Devlin and Glenn knew how to handle a fucking troglodyte like Johnny Rumble.

With Rumble's leathery mitt still on her upturned bottom, Minka thumbed down her panties at one side, revealing her ass. Johnny sat back so he wouldn't get in the way of her work, admiring what she revealed to them all. The panties came down, showing them her white ass, swaying to the music, the panties catching between her thighs a second before tugging free and falling to the floor. Rumble scooted forward and palmed both cheeks again, parting them. Minka allowed him, going on her tip-toes and shaking her buns for Johnny. He spanked her ass harder this time, making Minka yelp. Josh's heart stopped, imagining in a terrified moment that the door would open, security would come to Minka's aid and they would all end up in jail tonight. He'd have to tell Kimmy what happened, how he didn't want to be here at all, how he couldn't say no. But it would be humiliating. And what if it went on his record and jeopardized his job, maybe even ruining this promotion he'd just been awarded, canceling his trip to Italy?

His skin prickled with green unease and he shifted and squirmed in his chair.

But Rumble wasn't the first aggressive customer Minka had ever experienced, and she just stepped away and spun around, letting all of them see her pussy. Josh could hear Rumble growl beside him, even over the music. Then she spun once more, elegant, like maybe she'd done ballet back in Russia, sitting backwards on the chair with her forearms over the seat back, legs wide open, giving all of them a much better view of the space between her thighs.

“Look at that pink fucking monkey,” Rumble said through gritted teeth and elbowed Josh in the arm hard enough to hurt.

Minka humped the chair, rocking her pussy back and forth on the seat, showing it, hiding it, showing it. Josh’s anxiety raced, thinking any second Rumble would lose any cool he might have, lurch forward and grab Minka and end the night with the cops showing up and putting them all in handcuffs.

Thank God the song ended. They paid by the dance, and once the song was over, that was it. Minka stood, naked in high heels, and accepted her camisole, Glenn offering it back to her with a sly but reassuring smile. She covered up her front bits without putting the camisole on, draping it across her body like a toreador before a bull. With her Russian accent, she said, “Do you want to go again?”

Rumble looked at Devlin like Devlin was his daddy, an almost childish, pleading look in his bloodshot, drunken eyes. Josh sneered in his mind, making a low-IQ cartoon voice for the belligerent piece of shit, saying in his head, “Please, Daddy, make the girl do another dance for me.” He couldn’t help chuckling at the hilarious notion, but hid it away in case Rumble caught him and knew exactly what he was thinking. Josh couldn’t see Devlin, but Devlin must have agreed. Devlin paid the bill tonight. Each dance cost a hundred dollars, the security guy outside the room logging the time and the number of songs for them.

Rumble rubbed his hands on his knees, rocking with horny greed, sucking his teeth and looking at Minka. He had a great idea, leaning forward to say to Devlin past Josh: “Let’s get that Chinese one in here with her.”

Josh could see Glenn wince and laugh. He nudged Johnny's bulky arm, saying, "Easy, big boy. Josh's wife is Asian."

Rumble was angered. "So? What the fuck'd I say was so bad?" Then he turned and glared at Josh like it was his fault, though Josh had said nothing at all.

Instant icy fear chilled his heart and Josh put up his hands in surrender. "It's fine with me, man."

Already forgotten, Rumble said to Minka, "Tell your guy to bring up that Asian girl. You guys do a deal for two dancers?"

Minka said in her cold Russian way: "No."

Rumble scoffed, said, "Then just bring up the Asian. You're done. We already saw your cookie."

Glenn pinched the bridge of his nose and sighed, "Jesus."

Minka had dealt with assholes before and she showed no expression, gathering up her things from the floor—out of Rumble's reach—then leaving the room saying nothing else.

Rumble was back at Josh right away, defensive and arrogant. “I didn’t say anything bad about Chinese people, man.”

Josh was still in surrender, hands up. “I know, I know.”

Devlin, still lounged and easy-going, said, “Josh’s wife is hotter than any of the girls here. You can say anything to him and he’s still the winner. It’s why he’s not even paying attention, that girl humping her cooch on the chair.”

Rumble was pleased, nodding, looking at Josh with new respect. He leaned to the side toward Glenn and grabbed his nine-dollar bottle of Labatt Blue and swigged from it. He wiped his lips and said to Josh, “Oh yeah? She’s fucking hot, huh?”

“Smoking hot,” Devlin said.

It soured Josh’s stomach, but he didn’t show it on his face. One look of weakness and Rumble would be on him like a dog on a steak. Then Devlin said, “She went to Dalton. You don’t remember her?”

Rumble said, “How would I know her? I don’t even know her name. You know how many Chinese girls went to Dalton?”

“You know her,” Devlin said.

Rumble gestured at Josh. “I don’t even know this guy. How’m I going to remember his wife?”

Devlin nudged Josh. “Show him Kimmy’s picture.”

Josh moved cautiously, getting his phone out of his pocket, hoping the subject would change, but Rumble had patience when it came to looking at a hot Asian wife. He woke his phone and found a recent picture of Kimmy; one where she was wearing her suit with her hair up and all her makeup, lips in crimson.

“Ho-lee fucking shit,” Rumble said with horny intent, and took Josh’s phone from him, holding it closer for a good look. “What’s her name?”

Devlin said, “Kimmy. Kimmy Chang.”

“I’d remember this fucking chick. No way she went to Dalton.”

Josh reached for his phone, saying, “She didn’t look like that in high school,” but Rumble was too enamored with Kimmy’s picture, shifting so Josh couldn’t reach it.

“Holy shit, this is your wife? How the fuck did you get that? No offense.” He began thumb-swiping through older pictures and Josh’s armpits went hot and sweaty, still reaching for his phone but held at bay by Rumble’s threatening bulk.

Devlin eased closer to Josh, saying to Johnny, “Give him his phone back,” and Rumble did so with no question. But now his attention had been distracted by Devlin offering his own phone.

Josh took his phone back and swiftly hid it away in his pocket, while Rumble took Devlin’s phone and huddled over it like he was sitting on the toilet. Josh leaned forward, curious to see what had the idiot’s attention.

A photo of Kimmy on Devlin’s phone.

TAILGATE

EARLIER IN THE DAY

At lunch they split a Sake Salmon Bowl, picking up their order from the restaurant, then bringing it back to Devlin's apartment. Sashimi salmon, served on rice marinated in sake and soy, ginger on the side and a wasabi mayo. They ate standing at the kitchen island in their work clothes. The morning had been spent down at the union office, the Shoreman Association in the Lower Don Lands by Cherry Beach. She'd stayed silent the whole time while Devlin talked to the Chief, there as intimidation to make Devlin's words seem more palatable when compared to implied legal complications.

They alternated turns taking slices of the salmon, Devlin with a fork, her with chopsticks. She said, "You're going back to the city after lunch?"

"I'm only here for one thing. You going back to the office?"

"Yup," she said, slipping the cold fish past her lips.

“Big night tonight,” Devlin said, smiling to himself, eyes turned down for his turn to spear the sashimi.

“Josh is parking in the office underground, and I’m driving him to the subway.”

“Aww, that’s nice.”

Kimmy raised an eyebrow. “You’re going to be good to him tonight.”

Devlin forked salmon into his mouth, but raised two fingers. When he was mostly done chewing, he said, “Scout’s Honor.”

She showed him a look of doubt, picking up a slice of the fish between the points of her chopsticks.

Devlin said, “But I might have some surprises,” setting down his fork and wiping his hands on a paper napkin from the takeout bag.

Kimmy paused with the salmon held near her mouth, waiting to see what Devlin would say next, waiting to determine if it was a joke or some semblance of truth. “What kind of surprise?”

Devlin sighed and cocked his head, sucking his teeth and studying her through calm, narrowed eyes. “Are you worried?”

She said, “You should be worried.”

“About what?”

“What I’ll do to you if you hurt Josh.”

Devlin chuckled heartily, smiling wide, black eyes gleaming.

She said, “I’m serious.”

“I don’t doubt you are,” he said, taking up his glass of chilled chardonnay and sipping.

“Then what’s so funny?” She eyed him scrupulously, putting the salmon in her mouth and chewing.

Devlin set his wine down and faced her, not answering, but instead cupping her jaw, then easing out one of the sticks that held her bun in place. The bun loosened and fell to one side along her neck. She leaned her cheek to rest it on the cup of Devlin’s large palm. He thumbed her lower lip.

She said, “If you hurt him, I swear I’ll make you pay.”

Devlin’s eyebrows bowed at her warning, skeptical and dismissive. He said, “You’re the only one who can hurt him, Kimmy.”

She rolled her eyes—to Devlin’s amusement—but couldn’t deny there was a point to his claim. She tossed her chopsticks into their rice bowl and huffed. “You’re using me to get to Josh.”

Devlin let her cheek go and folded her arms, while she rose to stand tall in front of him and properly undid her bun.

“I don’t want to hurt Josh. I’m doing him a favor.”

“You’re so fucking full of shit,” she said, laughing, and shaking out her hair, running her nails through it.

Devlin chuckled too, and cocked his head, admiring her with her hair down. “There’s some truth in what I’m saying. You know there is.” He unfolded his arms and began to work out the top button at the collar of her black silk shirt. She slipped off her jacket and tossed it on a clean space on the island’s marble countertop. They’d danced around all kinds of dirty ideas, and she’d toyed with playing Josh’s erotic guitar strings, but the closer they got to confronting Josh with it, the more insane she thought the idea was.

With her shirt unbuttoned all the way down and untucked from her pants, Devlin traced a finger down her collarbones, between her breasts, down her stomach. She shrugged out of the shirt, eyeing him again with scrutiny.

She asked him, “So what is it we’re saying?”

Devlin tugged her closer with his finger hooked on her waistband. Her hands went to his suit lapels. “Both of us want Josh to know what we’re doing.”

“No, I don’t,” she said. “Maybe you do, but I don’t.”

His arms went around her and she melted into his determined embrace. His strong hands unhooked her bra strap. In tall heels like this, her mouth rested near his neck. He whispered in her ear, “Yeah, you do. You want him to know and you want him to be okay with it. You don’t want him to hate you. You’re so afraid he’ll hate you.”

She stepped back from him, letting him keep her bra, standing topless before him in only slate grey suit pants and high heels. Devlin wound her bra around one hand like a boxer’s wrap, then shuffled the bra off his hand and plopped it next to her suit jacket, eyeing her, sure of his words but not antagonizing her further.

“Of course,” she said, looking away. “That’s not a genius’s take.”

“I’m not trying to impress you with my perception. I’m trying to be honest with you. All three of us are mixed up in this thing you and I started, and all of us know deep in our hearts we’d rather not hide it anymore.”

She raised her chin in some small measure of defiance. “I thought Josh started it.”

Devlin smiled and stepped closer, cupping a hand to her rib cage, sliding it upward and thumbing over her erect nipple.

Her lashes fluttered, always loving the way his manly hands stroked her body. “Did Josh start it?”

Devlin’s dark expression focused on his hands as he brought them together and unhooked the waistband of her suit pants. He unzipped them, pushed them to her hips, eyes still turned down. “God, your fucking body, Kimmy.” The pants slipped below her ass, revealing her panties.

She said, “Did he ask for all of this?”

Devlin only smiled, his eyes not on hers now, but on her breasts, watching his thumb circle her nipple. She raised his chin, and he met her eyes. He said, “In his way.”

She dropped her finger from his chin and rolled her eyes, stepping back and crossing her arms over her naked chest. “Oh God, so cloak and dagger.”

Devlin held her waist on either side and lifted her up to sit her panty-covered ass on the cold marble countertop. Her fine wool pants bunched at her knees, and Devlin removed them, careful getting them over her heels. Pants tossed at her side, he began to caress her ankles and knees, opening them to stand between her open thighs. She was naked but for panties and heels; he was fully clothed in a suit and tie and platinum cufflinks.

When his mouth approached hers, she closed her eyes, let him take her kiss, touching her throat and collar. He said, “You’ve asked me all this before, Kimmy. My answer isn’t going to change. Whatever happened that night with Josh at Tiff’s cottage was all in his head. But it’s to our benefit.” His broad hand stroked up and down on her breastbone, his thumb and pinky flicking over her nipples.

She raised her chin again. “What are you going to do to him?”

“Give him everything he ever dreamed of.”

“What’s that?”

Now he kissed her neck, his voice a whisper near her ear. “Watching me with you.”

She shook her head, ran her fingers through the hair at Devlin's neck. "He'd never agree. Never want it."

He held her face in his hands and looked into her eyes. "You know deep down I'm right."

"No, I don't. I only hope he will. He won't ever want it."

Devlin shook his head like he was disappointed in her. "You're lying to yourself. It turns you on. What we're doing turns you on. And what it's doing to Josh is starting to turn you on, too."

"That's crazy, Devlin."

"Is it? You get off on it. You've thought about Josh watching us. Hell, you've said those words to me." His hand fell to her collar, then slid lower, down her middle to the crotch of her panties. She moaned and rolled her head on her neck at his masculine touch.

She said, "That's just dirty talk."

"That's how it starts."

As he began to knuckle-roll circles on her heat, she whispered, “Tell me what you’re going to do to him tonight.”

“Drinks, Jays game. I have some surprises planned.”

Her hands gripped his shoulders, hard muscle under expensive fabric.
“Don’t hurt him.”

“I won’t. Do you believe me when I say I won’t?”

“No.”

“Aw, Kimmy. You wound me.”

“I know you.”

Devlin slipped his hand down the front of her panties and touched her slick labia. Her spread-out thighs quivered.

Devlin said, “I can’t hurt him anymore.”

“Only I can,” she finished for him.

“That’s right.”

“You want to use me against him.”

He held the side of her neck and thumbed up her jaw to get her to meet his eyes. “Come on, Kimmy. You think Josh doesn’t know what we’re doing? You don’t think he’s lying to himself? You come home late, you take a long lunch, you’re acting weird, you and me we spend so much time together . . .”

“And you’re you.”

Devlin liked that, chuckling in his throat. “And Josh knows exactly who I am.” He eased his middle finger into her wet and eager pussy. “You don’t think he knows? Let him off the hook already, you fucking bitch.”

She scoffed, offended, then jokingly grabbed his nipple through his shirt and squeezed. Devlin withdrew his finger, laughed in her face and let her do it, challenging her to do it harder if she dared. And she did dare, pinching and twisting. Devlin batted away her grip with his hefty forearm. Chortling, but wincing from her digital punishment. He smoothed it with his palm, scowling at her now. Then he brightened, grabbed his growing endowment through his pants and shook it. “Why are you so mean to Josh? Why don’t you give that man what he needs?”

“What’s your thing with Josh, anyway? You have such a hard-on for my husband.”

“I don’t give the slightest fuck for Josh Waters, Kimmy.” He returned to her, slipping his hands around to massage her back. “I swear to sweet baby Jesus that I haven’t thought of him since the last day of high school. The only thing I got for him is maybe a small amount of aggravation. That he could get you. He could get a woman like you and let her shrivel on the vine. Look what Josh made you. Then look what I made you.”

“I was happy with Josh. I am happy with Josh.”

“When I met you, you were making kitty cat baskets.”

“That was a ‘thing.’ You know it was a thing. I told you what it was. Don’t use something personal against me.”

He nodded to her in apology. “I wasn’t talking about your thing. That wasn’t the point. Even when you were working, you were making fifty-k as a polyester civil servant.”

“I was making more than that,” she muttered.

“A man would never be satisfied seeing something so fine just fizzle.”

She huffed a tiny laugh, her eyes roaming up to his. “So that’s your thing with Josh.”

“No, Kimmy. That’s your thing with Josh. It just hasn’t occurred to you yet. It’s starting to.”

Her lips wriggled, and she tested all sorts of feisty responses, but none came to her lips.

“Think back to Cayman,” he said. “You chose to take Josh. You didn’t have to. Who would you have had more fun with? Josh Waters or Devlin Stone? Whose feelings and sensibilities do you have to spare or skirt? And who treats you like a woman? Who respects you, and who fears you?”

“He doesn’t fear me.”

With condescending sympathy, he stroked her cheek, saying, “Oh honey, you make him shake in his boots.”

No more words came. Devlin was right. As she chewed her cheek and moved her mouth around, trying to formulate some defense, he gripped her waist again and lifted her off the counter. She hooked her legs around his waist and looped her arms around his powerful neck.

With her clinging to him, he walked around the island and up the three steps to the pristine living room, heading to the couch. His hands palmed her ass, and she kissed his neck. She whispered, “Where are you taking me?”

“Places you never thought you’d go.” His large finger slipped under the edge of her panties and teased at her anus, getting her gasping.

“And what are you going to do to me?”

“Give you everything you thought you’d never have.”

SLEEPOVER 1

Past Rumble's leering profile, Josh could see Kimmy in a familiar outfit: a silky black tank top, thin spaghetti straps over her shoulders.

Rumble said, "This is the same girl? Shit, yeah, it is. Letting her hair down."
"

Glenn scooted to Rumble's other shoulder to get a look at a different picture of Josh's hot wife. Josh knew the outfit, but not where the picture had been taken.

Rumble stated the thing that was obvious but should not have been said aloud: "You can see her little fucking nip-nips."

Yes, Kimmy had not worn a bra that night, and her nipples were sometimes visible through the fabric.

Devlin said, "Don't you fucking dare swipe through my photos."

Glenn chuckled then looked behind Rumble's simian back, saying to Josh, "She's beautiful, man."

"Thanks," Josh said, low and sullen, his guts squirming like a nest of poisonous snakes. What would those other photos show?

Rumble passed Devlin's phone back to him. "Where was this?"

"My hotel room."

While Josh grimaced and squirmed, Rumble scoffed with hilarious disbelief that Devlin would say it in front of the woman's husband. "Whoah, holy shit, man."

"Fuck off, it's not like that," Devlin said and laughed, tucking his phone inside his pocket. "Kimmy drove me home after dinner. Dinner with all three of us. We were all in Cayman together."

"Oh, fuck—the cottage?" Glenn said it like he was personally familiar with the place and a lot of nefarious hijinks had occurred there.

But the question remained: so what if she drove you home—why would you take her picture? How did that come about? And why was Kimmy gone so long that night? He'd waited in the hot tub forever for her return.

Maybe if he'd read the time stamp on Devlin's photo of her . . .

What? What would it tell him? Probably something he didn't want to know.

Rumble swigged his beer and said, "That girl did not go to Dalton."

"Yeah, she did," Devlin said, amused. And now he retrieved his phone from the pocket where he'd just hidden it. He swiped the screen, looking for something, finding it after a moment and passing the phone back to Rumble. "There. That's at Dalton."

Rumble chuckled at the photo. A picture from Kimmy's Facebook. Devlin was Kimmy's friend on Facebook. No big deal, right? The picture showed Amy with an oversized sweatshirt, the collar falling over one shoulder, her crimson hair in long tangles, making a sexy face for the camera. Kimmy was next to her, long black hair, face twisted into a strange grimace of hilarity. Practically an ugly picture. She was laughing so hard her eyes were black dashes and she showed her teeth with braces. She also wore a sweatshirt, this one pale pink, a buttoned shirt underneath. She was skinny and fragile and perfect. His heart ached for those simpler times.

Though that wasn't even true. Even back then, their relationship had been strange and temporary; fleeting at times. They'd kissed, and she'd traveled afterwards, and when she returned from Taiwan, the spark seemed quashed.

“That’s her?”

“That’s Kimmy Chang,” Devlin said.

Rumble batted the screen with the backs of his fingers with a declaration of clarity. “Now it makes sense. Now it makes sense.” He tapped his fat index finger on Amy’s face. “Amy I fucking remember. This one I don’t. But that’s how you got her, right?” He faced Josh with his beer-blurred eyes, menacing but good-natured for now, demanding the appropriate response from Josh, but leaving it up to Josh to decide what wouldn’t anger him. Devlin took his phone back, and again Josh wondered what secrets that device would reveal to him.

Josh said, “What do you mean?”

Rumble wavered, blinking, eyes wet and narrow. In that long moment, Josh could imagine having offended him in some unforeseen way and Johnny hauling off and punching him. But Johnny didn’t punch him, instead saying, “That’s how you got her, bro. Right? Fuck, now I see it. No way you’d get that girl now.” Somehow, it wasn’t intended to be a provocative insult. Johnny said it like it was a matter of fact, plain as day.

But it left Josh bashed and wounded, wondering why he’d ever agreed to come out tonight with Devlin Stone. What had he wanted from this? To play in what he would consider “the big leagues?” With a bunch of fucking assholes. Well, Glenn was all right. Devlin brought Johnny Rumble on purpose just to fuck with him. Arranged this whole conversation. Pretend you don’t remember her and you want to see a picture, then I’m going to

show you one where she was alone with me in my hotel room. And Rumble said, “Did you fuck her?” And Devlin looked at Rumble like he was crazy. “Of course I fucked her.”

Devlin hooked an arm around Josh’s neck and hugged him close, the two of them side by side, Devlin leaning nearer to Rumble, saying, “He didn’t get her in high school, dip-shit.”

Rumble laughed and held up his hands like the insult was uncalled for. “What the fuck?” He looked at Glenn like he couldn’t believe Devlin would call him a dip-shit for nothing.

Devlin squeezed Josh’s neck like he was a good buddy, snatched his phone from Rumble and sat back again, looking at high-school Kimmy and smiling before putting the phone in his pocket.

Rumble looked at Josh now, amused and not angry, shaking his head and shrugging his shoulders like he didn’t see what the big deal was. “Hey, it’s not an insult, it’s a fucking compliment, buddy.” Then to Glenn: “This guy should be in finance, get a client in on the ground floor, turn you into a billionaire in ten years.”

Josh muttered, “We met up again at university.”

The door to their private room opened a crack, hallway light spilling in. Someone still held the door handle, an unseen woman, pausing to talk with the security guy standing out front. Johnny scooted forward in his seat and

lay back, his hands frantically working down his zipper as quick as he could. Just as Josh looked over to see what he was doing, Rumble hauled out a bloated pound of flaccid cock meat wagging in his grip.

Glenn scowled and hissed, “For fuck’s sake,” looking away.

Rumble had pulled his cock out of the fly of his boxers, now let it dangle free from them, but zipped up his pants again. He manhandled his thing through his trousers, getting it into position, laying it sideways so you could see it under the fabric. He caught Josh looking and the disgust on Josh’s face. But instead of being angered, he laughed like he enjoyed being gross, and elbowed Josh. “That’s how you get a lap dance the right way.” He bit his lower lip and held the ass of an imaginary woman sitting in his lap ass-first, wagging his hips and humping his cock-bulge into the air, giving the imaginary woman a ride.

The door opened further as the stripper came in, and now Rumble muttered, “Better be that Asian.”

It was.



In the Uber on their way home, Kimmy asked Hyun if she wanted to stay over.

“At your place?”

“Yeah. Meyer has Sophie till Monday, Josh is staying in the city. He’ll be home in the morning. Why don’t we all do brunch together?”

She watched Hyun’s face go through the range of polite responses saying why she wouldn’t, but could see a gleam in her eye and a slight raise to one corner of her mouth, knowing Hyun couldn’t wait to say yes.

While Hyun pretended to vacillate, Kimmy said, “Are you doing anything tomorrow?”

Hyun said, “No . . .” in a long, draggy way, still resisting the urge to jump in with both feet.

“Come on,” Kimmy said, swaying to shoulder-bump Hyun. “It’s not even late. We can watch TV, eat some junk food, talk a little more . . .”

Hyun bobbed her head a little, smiling now. “Yeah. Yeah, that might be good.”



Hyun hesitated coming out of the bathroom, lurking in the dark, shy and sheepish.

Kimmy, sitting on the couch in the family room, said down the dark hall, “Do they fit?”

From the dark bathroom: “Yeah.” Hyun’s knee clicked in the quiet of the hall, stepping out now from the bathroom and padding down the hall with her hands tucked up the insides of the borrowed sweatshirt’s sleeves.

As she came into the family room, Kimmy asked her, “Comfy?”

“Oh, yeah,” Hyun agreed, nodding, letting her host know she appreciated pajamas to sleep in. Hyun wore a purple hoodie, Veritas et Utilitas written on the front, Western Law in puffy letters on the sleeve.

She’d loaned Hyun an old sweatshirt and a pair of pajama shorts, fresh from the laundry. She said, “That sweatshirt was the comfiest I had. I pulled a lot of all-nighters in that.”

Hyun held the hem and pulled it down a little lower. Kimmy had bought it in Size Large specifically for it to be roomy and comfy. Hyun said, “Studying?”

“That’s all I did in Law School. Josh was working, I was out in London. What else was I going to do?” Though, even if Josh had moved to London to stay with her, studying all night was still what she would have done.

Hyun came closer and sat on the couch, drawing her bare feet up and sitting cross-legged like Kimmy was. The TV was on, the Netflix menu showing, a huge ceramic bowl of extra-buttery popcorn on the table and two glasses of white wine.

Now Kimmy said, “What do you want to watch? Rom-com, horror, comedy . . .?”

“Something funny’s good.” Hyun reached for her glass and took a timid sip.

While Kimmy cycled through the viewing options on Netflix, she said, “One good thing about getting a house is having a little more space. We lost our guest room when I turned it into my studio.”

“You don’t make any baskets anymore?”

Kimmy shook her head no, still searching for a comedy she hadn’t seen. “I want you to take my bed, and I’ll sleep out here on the couch.”

Hyun set her wineglass down, saying, “Oh, no way, Kimmy, no way. I’m not kicking you out of your bed.”

“I don’t mind the couch, Hyun. It’s a comfortable couch.”

“Then I’ll take the couch.”

Kimmy found a movie she hadn’t seen, “Everything Must Go.” She said, “Have you seen this? It’s got Will Ferrell.”

Hyun shook her head no, that she hadn’t seen the movie. “Let me take the couch, Kimmy.”

Kimmy chuckled and turned her head to Hyun. She looked sweet and innocent and adorable, her brows knitted with worry about who would sleep where, and hoping she wasn’t an imposition. Kimmy cocked her head. “I can’t sleep with you out here on the couch when it should be me, Hyun.”

She smiled a little, sweeping her hand on the couch seat. “I thought you said it was a comfortable couch.”

“It is, it is. . . . Hey, Josh isn’t here. It’s a big bed.” She shrugged and made a funny face, like there was an obvious answer both of them hadn’t seen yet. “Why don’t we just watch TV in the bedroom, sleepover style?”

PROMISES

EARLIER IN THE DAY

Devlin set her naked back on the leather couch with her arms still around his neck. The cold leather got her to gasp and Devlin stole it with his mouth. Kissing was a rarity between them, and she was perturbed with him today, so she turned her face away, running her nails through his thick black hair. He rose above her, one knee on the couch seat, his other foot on the floor, stroking her thighs and knees, pushing her legs so she would unhook them from his middle, then laying her calves on his shoulders.

“These fucking legs,” he growled, large masculine hands going up and down, white-gold Patek Philippe on his wrist, French cuffs and cuff links matching his watch. There was something so sexy about being naked with him when he was still clothed. She wished she’d worn stockings today. As it was, the sight was still insanely erotic: her long, toned legs, her rose-flower panties, her black Gucci pumps with the four-inch gold stiletto heels. Devlin had paid for this expensive apartment solely as a place for them to fuck in.

She gripped his tie and pulled it, encouraging him closer, but when she tried to undo the knot, he stopped her. “I’m keeping it on.”

“Your tie?”

“All of it.”

She narrowed her eyes. “You’re going to fuck me in your suit?”

“This is what I’m wearing tonight. I want your smell on me. I want to breathe you all night long.”

“You’re crazy,” she whispered, writhing on the couch seat, hungry for more of his touch.

“I’m wearing your scent tonight.” His hand went to her collar, spread out full breadth, and her nipples ached. If only he’d squeeze them as hard as she’d squeezed his. She arched her back again, put one arm over her head on the sofa pillow, thrusting her chest toward him, closing her eyes. Devlin’s hand slid down her torso, collar to sternum, brushing over her nipples and getting her groaning. His hand curled at her navel, the backs of his fingers sliding on her skin now, diving under her panties and ruffling through her pubic hair.

Now she let go a plaintive cry of forbidden pleasure at his touch. His fingers slipped through her flooding wetness. “What if Josh smells you on me and doesn’t go tonight?”

“He’ll miss out on a lot of fun. What, you think Joshy will smell my aftershave on you and go wild? Just get crazy—take you into the backseat and try to prove to you you’re his?”

“I am his,” she said, raking her fingertips down his hard thighs.

“You’re not all his,” he said with a movie-villain chuckle, easing two large fingers inside her, not very deep, but reminding her canal of his large intrusion and the need to be prepared. But she gushed. She could feel how she gushed. Some days this last while she couldn’t wait to meet Devlin. Got the shakes when the time came near where they might find time to meet here in his apartment this way. Her pussy had been conditioned to behave for Devlin. He provided some deep dark thing she needed; her brain, her body, her pussy. She humped against his hand. Loving the feel of how slick she was, and how easily his greased fingers worked in and out of her. Devlin loomed over her, loving his effect, watching her go into heat for him.

His fingers left her, stroking up the plump curled lips of her entrance, so engorged and full for Devlin. He eased down the waistband of her panties, sliding them down slowly to reveal her pussy. She sucked in her stomach, showed off her toned stomach and the muscles at her hips; she’d been working out again and nowadays she thought of Devlin’s eyes on her when she did.

He urged her legs to one shoulder now, ducking his head to accommodate them, then slowly ran the panties up her legs, then off her feet, snagging the dampened crotch on one Gucci heel. With her balled panties in one fist, he parted her legs, opened them again so they were spread wide, her pussy bared. She put one foot on the back of the couch, the other planted stiletto-

down onto the leather seat behind Devlin. He brushed the back of his hand up her wetness, making her shudder, then showed her he was putting her panties in his jacket pocket.

“You’re going back to the office without these.”

She gasped as if it were the most outrageous thing she’d ever heard. “No panties at work?”

“Not the first time, Kimmy. Besides, I want your pussy bare when you drive your husband to the subway.”

Something rolled over in her guts. No, higher—high enough to bump against her heart. She thought of driving Josh tonight, making chit-chat, being nice but knowing she was sending him off to danger; knowing Devlin sought to arrange Josh where his wife wanted him.

Which was where?

It was like she was offloading this complicated puzzle to someone else. Didn’t she have the nerve to deal with Josh herself? If she did, she would tell him the truth. Confess her sins and let the dust settle and see where he’d left her.

But that was dull and unexciting.

Surrendering her husband to the whims of this devil was thrilling and dangerous, and it sparked light in her darkest corners, made things hot and electric, sizzling bright life through her synapses. She couldn't live in sin. She couldn't stop with Devlin, not yet. If she confessed, Josh would leave her.

There was nothing left to lose.

She held the fine fabric of his lapels in her grip as he fingered her again. She said, "He's coming to meet you tonight."

"You're delivering him to me."

She bit her lower lip as a thrilling, wild wave of pleasure washed up from her core. "Don't hurt him."

"Not at all, Kimmy. But I want him to smell your heat before he leaves you. Smell your sex, smell your arousal." He drew his finger up now and touched them on her lower lip.

She said, "And then smell me on you."

He slipped a finger past her lips, but she turned her head and complained.

Devlin rose to his knees again, her legs on either side of him, and began to draw down his zipper. She could make out the bulk of his hard cock under the fabric; engorged but hanging down one pant leg. He said, “You need it so bad. You’re aching for it.”

Devlin hauled out his cock, having to shove down his pants to withdraw the monstrous thing, the leather harness of his silk braces pulled to their limit. When it was out it fell to hang heavily between her open thighs. Long and thick, the head a massive swollen thing, the skin stretched tight and shining now that it was out and still growing. She watched the veins begin to rise on the shaft.

“Fuck, I love your cock,” she said.

He held it in the middle and began to stroke the topside of the head against her opening. The sticky clicking sound drove her wild, and when she flexed her stomach, the sweat of her arousal flooded more, trickling down her ass crack onto the leather.

“Please, fuck me,” she moaned, writhing, lifting her arms over head and tucking them under the sofa pillow. The sight of him this way, so dominant and masculine and nefarious, excited her in a whole different way—the suit showed his power, his status; the apartment purchased to fuck her in showed his wealth; the size of his manhood showed his masculinity. No wonder she couldn’t stop fucking him.

He wedged the plum of his cock head into the slick cushion of her canal, then began to push inside her. As he pierced her tightest ring, she flexed her thighs and pushed herself into the couch, holding her breath. At last he was inside her, her muscles surrendering their futile contraction, loosening and allowing the oversized intrusion. The fullness was incredible. The intense stretch was something she craved when she was with Josh. And she was so wet the discomfort of his size washed away in seconds and was replaced with a rising tide of deep pleasure.

“Oh fuck,” she sighed, as though what she’d needed had arrived at last.

He pushed in and out in short strokes, his cock still enlarging, even inside her. “You feel so fucking good, Kimmy,” he said.

“Oh, God,” she moaned, crossing her eyes with a forearm, a dark desirous question bubbling up to her surface: “What are you going to do to my husband?”

“We’re not watching superhero movies.”

She panted: “What are you— Ah, what are you going to do?”

He pushed deeper. “Baseball. Bourbon. Cigars. Strip club.”

She scowled under her forearm. “Don’t you dare.”

“Trust me, anything Josh or I see in a strip club is going to be a letdown when we both have you.”

She moved her arm away and sneered. “You don’t have me.”

“Strange thing to say with your pussy gripping my cock.”

“You’re such an asshole,” she sighed, arching her back, showing Devlin her throat, letting his hand stroke it.

“I’m going to make him a man. I’m going to point out to him the man inside, and if he doesn’t find it that way, he never will.”

“Josh is a man.”

“Strange thing to say with your—”

She swatted his cheek and then wedged her thumb webbing into his mouth, saying, “Don’t you fucking dare.”

Devlin chuckled, easing his hips back, easing them forward, throbbing pleasure emanating from the tight stretch he delivered so deep. He bit the meat of her thumb carefully. No pain, just the clamping sensation, and she moaned and rolled her head on the sofa's arm pillow. Devlin thumbed her chin while he fucked her and clamped her thin hand in his mouth.

Devlin grumbled, "Do you think he'll find that man, Kimmy? Do you think he can find it inside him?"

"Yeah," she gasped, unintended doubt curling her tone. What man was he to find?

Devlin chuckled, hooked a hand under her knee and brought her leg bending high toward her chin. He released his teeth-clamp on her hand, rolled her over, hoisting her hips like she was weightless, getting her face down on the couch, the leather rubbing her nipples in an amazing way. His cock stayed inside her the whole time—but when he pushed inside from this new angle, her eyes rolled up in her sockets and she whimpered a low sound of ecstasy. She kicked one foot behind him, the other knee and toe-point sagging to touch the floor.

Though fear for Josh fluttered around her heart, something deeper, something strangely maternal, resisted compassion. Like a part of her wanted Josh challenged. Believed a challenge was good for him. Devlin fisted her hair and pulled her head back. She chuckled and moaned with delight and pain. He'd curved her like a C-shape, her stomach pushed into the cushion, her back arched; the way his cock stretched her had her whole body shaking. His cock was stiff and straight, and bowed like this, fucked deep from behind, pushed the point of his tremendous length on some visceral button. An orgasm shuddered through her and her bladder loosened.

Everything below her tummy went into a five-alarm frenzy. Her thighs shook and trembled and she grunted in tight coughs as her orgasm intensified. Her liquid pattering tinkled on the couch.

Devlin lowered, clung to her back, letting go of the bow he'd stretched her body into. He said in a low rumble near her ear.

“We’re going to get Josh’s little balls swollen like melons. He’s going to have weapons-grade blue balls. All he’s going to think about is me and you.”

“Oh-okay,” she panted.

“I swear to you, Kimmy,” he growled, “I’m going to have Josh begging you to fuck me.”

LAIR

The limo took them all the way to north Toronto, stopping on the way to drop off Glenn near Forest Hill. Johnny Rumble took a cab home from the strip club. It was almost three in the morning.

Josh smelled like cigar smoke and whisky and cloying perfume. Only one day out in his expensive new suit and he'd have to get it dry cleaned already.

Devlin walked ahead of him, working a kink out of his neck, waving a hand for Josh to follow, saying, "Come on into the kitchen."

In the kitchen Devlin doffed his suit coat and tossed it onto the glass kitchen table. Josh undid his tie and let it hang around his unbuttoned collar, coming to lean elbows on the kitchen island while Devlin went to the fridge.

Head in the fridge, Devlin said, "I hope you had a good time tonight."

“Yeah, it was great,” Josh said. “Thanks again. I appreciate the private seats.”

Devlin said, “Ah, don’t mention it. My pleasure. It was good having you there.” Devlin’s head stayed in the fridge, but he began passing things over onto the island. A tub of yogurt, lemons in a plastic bag...

Josh said, “What are you doing?”

Devlin pulled down containers from a kitchen cupboard now, setting them on the island, then undoing his cufflinks and rolling up his sleeves, “Pre-hangover remedy.” Now he moved a blender to the island and plugged it in. “Grass-fed Greek yogurt, coconut water, ginger, ginseng, milk thistle, lemon juice, sea salt. And a metric fuck-ton of B12.” He cut the lemons in half and Josh watched the muscles in his hairy forearms flex. He squeezed out the lemon halves into the blender, stopping to retrieve a single seed that had squirted in. Devlin whirled the concoction, then added more ingredients. “Add some BCAAs, some creatine...”

Josh said, “What, no fruit? No banana? No honey?”

Devlin narrowed his eyes on Josh like Josh was insane. “Before bed? No way, buddy. We’re trying to be healthy here.”

Josh smacked his lips and turned up his nose. “How do I get the taste of a cigar out of my mouth?”

Devlin eyed him over his shoulder. “That was a fucking Cuban, Josh. An eighty-dollar cigar.”

“Well, it’s certainly hanging around.”

“That’s supposed to be a good thing.”

“I suppose it is,” Josh muttered, hating to sound ungrateful. “I’d get used to it.”

Devlin pushed over the drink, poured in a tall glass, frothy and white like a milkshake. “Try that.”

Josh smelled it. “What’s this supposed to do for you?”

“Keep you fresh in the morning after a night of drinking. Help you sleep, banish the headache, settle the stomach.”

“We didn’t even drink that much,” Josh said, then tried the smoothie. Not terrible, but not sweet, and not what he expected when he tried a smoothie.

Devlin said, “Pretty wild seeing Rumble again.”

“You don’t see him usually?”

“Sometimes I do. I meant for you.”

Josh sipped and nodded, wiped his mouth. “I can’t believe he doesn’t remember me.”

Devlin dismissed it. “That guy’s brain is Swiss cheese. He’s a crazy boozier. Like, bottle a night most nights.”

“A bottle of what?”

“I don’t know,” he said, taking another drink—then with a second more consideration, added: “Rye. Rye was Johnny’s drink.”

“I feel like he should remember me.”

“Why’s that?”

Josh shrugged. It was unfair for Rumble's presence to stay in his life all these years, a manifestation of his teen powerlessness. Rumble didn't even remember him at all. He'd said, "From where—Dalton?" Of course from Dalton.

Devlin said, "Rumble is only important because you remember him."

Josh sipped his drink, manners dictating that though he'd like to toss it down the sink, he would finish it to be polite. He cleared his throat. "What does that mean?"

"Put it in perspective for you. Whatever hang-up you feel for Rumble is weightless. An absolute nothing. You could hold it in your palm"—he held up his palm—"and send it away." Now he puffed air into his palm and then dusted his hands like the matter was over.

"Because Johnny doesn't remember me."

"Right. Josh, whatever he did to you, it was nothing to him. You give him power. You give his memory power. In reality, that's all Johnny is—what you saw tonight?—that's all Johnny is. Stop giving him power."

"Sounds like metaphysical bullshit," Josh said, daring to speak his mind. It was late, and though it had been a weird and uncomfortable night, Devlin had been good to him. It felt acceptable.

Devlin laughed at his retort, enjoying the sparring. He took a sip of his smoothie, then said, “Yup, you sound exactly like Kimmy.”

Josh’s stomach squirmed. That was on purpose. Josh sensed it. Devlin sparred back. Call his pep-talk bullshit, and he had a weapon ready to maim you. Devlin had just flashed his trusty switchblade to Josh, warning him about the way he fought. No rules and very, very dirty.

He’d headed out tonight with an adventurous spirit. Asking himself: could he be friends with Devlin Stone? Devlin had been gracious, fun, and had showed Josh a good time. But if you ever forgot Devlin Stone’s cruelty, he would make you regret it.

Devlin drained his smoothie, set the glass back down on the countertop, then patted at his pockets. He went to the kitchen table and lifted his jacket, saying to Josh as he passed, “Are you going to tell Kimmy you went to a strip club?”

Josh swiveled on the stool. “If I don’t, are you going to tell her?”

Devlin smiled, withdrew his iPhone from the jacket, then shook his head no and crossed his heart—mannerisms not bolstering any confidence at all.

“Of course I’m going to tell her,” Josh said. “We don’t keep secrets.”

Devlin checked messages on his phone. “I’ll vouch you didn’t get a lap dance or a blowjob.”

“She’ll know I didn’t.”

Devlin set his phone down on the table, then returned to the island, slapping Josh on the back as he passed. “You’re a good kid, huh?”

Josh agreed, nodding. “I’m a good kid.”

“You ready to hit the hay?”



In the luxury apartment’s raised living room, Devlin gestured at the couch. “Best I can do, buddy.”

“It’s just fine,” Josh said. “I might just grab a couple hours of sleep and slip out before you even get up.”

“Oh, yeah, okay. If you want. You don’t want to grab some breakfast in the morning? I can drive you to the office to get your car.”

“Maybe. I’m just anxious to get home.”

Devlin said, “Kimmy sent a bag for you with your PJs. It’s on the floor at the end of the couch.”

“Got it.”

Devlin made to leave, but seemed guilty somehow. Turning, rubbing knuckles on his ribs, he said, “You sure you’re okay on the couch?”

“Totally fine. It’s a big couch. It looks really comfortable.”

“I have no furniture here. I have my bedroom set and a little bit of an office and that’s it. There’s a guest room, but it’s like completely empty.”

“The couch is fine, Devlin.”

Devlin nodded, then jerked a thumb over his shoulder. “I got a king size.”

Josh looked at him, unsure. Then said, “Are you bragging or something?”

Devlin laughed. “No, I mean, you could climb in with me if you wanted.”

“No, that’s all right.”

“Plenty of room.”

“I’m good on the couch,” Josh said, putting his hands in his pockets.

“Good,” Devlin said with satisfied finality. “I just didn’t want you going home and telling on me to Kimmy, like: ‘Devlin has this big bed and he makes me sleep on the couch.’ You know?”

“Why would I say that?”

“So Kimmy thinks I’m inhospitable.”

Josh shook his head, clear now that Devlin was fucking with him.

Devlin laughed, then said, “Hey, good night, man. I showed you the can, you know where the fridge is. You got a clean pillow there, a couple blankets. If you have to barf, just make sure—”

“I don’t have to barf,” Josh said.

“Not too much bourbon tonight, huh?”

“No.”

“Cigars can make you sick, man.”

“I know where the bathroom is.”

“All right, bud,” Devlin said, putting out a fist to be bumped. “We had a good time tonight. If you’re not here in the morning when I wake up, ciao. Say hi to Kimmy for me. And we’ll do this again, okay?”

Josh bumped knuckles, and Devlin held out a hand in farewell, heading down the hall toward his bedroom. He stopped, turned, saying, “Oh, hey. If you’re going to be away in Italy, you know what would be good?”

Josh took off his expensive jacket and lay it on the loveseat by the couch.
“What?”

“I’m going to offer my apartment to Kimmy. I’m like never here. She can use my pad so she doesn’t blow her pay check on gas going home to Ajax every night if she doesn’t have to. You know what I mean?”

Josh nodded, guts squirming again, and an uncomfortable thrill raced through his prostate, tightening his stomach. “Oh yeah, maybe.”

Devlin nodded, thinking to himself. “I think it’s a good idea. All right, night, Josh.”

“Good night, Devlin. Thanks for everything tonight.”

Devlin held up the farewell hand again and disappeared into the hallway’s darkness.

“Jesus fucking Christ,” Josh whispered to himself, squeezing the bridge of his nose.



On the floor at the end of the couch, Josh found the bag Kimmy had sent for him. A leather tote she’d packed the night before and brought along to work today. It was like being sent on a sleepover with the mean kid from school because your mother was friends with the mean kid’s mother. Only Devlin hadn’t been a mean kid tonight; he’d been decent.

He went down the hall to the bathroom and brushed his teeth, changed out of the suit, which he stored away in the zippered bag that came with it. He slipped into the sweatpants and T-shirt and padded down the dark hall, returning to the enormous leather couch where he'd sleep.

And there, only a dozen feet away and down three meager steps, he could see the dark shape of Devlin's suit jacket on the glass kitchen table, and next to it the black rectangle of Devlin's phone. His fingers tingled.

Josh lay his suit on a padded chair with his bag, tucked away his toiletry kit, and turned to look into the kitchen. The lights were off, but from the splash of pale light thrown by the clock on the stove, he could see a device that held many secrets. Or perhaps held none. That was what he would most like to think: that there was nothing incriminating on Devlin's phone. Nothing was happening behind his back.

But wouldn't that be a great idea then: to check the phone and find the relief you deserve?

If there was nothing on the phone, and he believed there wasn't, why even bother to check? Because Devlin had a photo of Kimmy that the more Josh considered, the more illicit it seemed. Why on earth would he take a picture of Kimmy in his hotel room?

If something was going on, then the obvious question was: why the fuck would Devlin dare show off the picture in Josh's presence?

Back to basics answer: Devlin was a bully and a fucking asshole.

Given that clear truth then, it could be equally considered that Devlin showed the picture specifically because there was no nefarious connection to it at all, but he loved to stir the pot. Devlin was drawn to meanness, and he couldn't help himself, even when he was otherwise being decent.

Josh stepped down into the kitchen, eyes on Devlin's phone. The thing would be password protected, so what was the point?

He could always wait until he heard Devlin snoring and sneak into the bedroom and face scan him, open the phone's security that way, slink into the washroom and find out everything that's been going on.

Yeah, right, like you would ever do that.

Years of conditioning told him what would happen. Devlin would kick the door open and beat the shit out of him. Maybe call Rumble over and they could tie him to a kitchen chair and take turns punching him in the stomach.

But that wouldn't happen. Not anymore. The shit you could get away with when you were fourteen, you couldn't get away with now. He'd press charges against Devlin. He'd sue him. He would have the upper hand. In fact, it would almost be worth getting the shit kicked out of him—hey, it

wouldn't be the first time—for the power over Devlin it would bestow. Devlin in jail for assault. A civil suit.

He stepped back up the stairs, looking around now in the corners of the dark room, imagining Devlin three steps ahead of him, leaving the phone there on purpose to tempt him, and meanwhile security cameras with night-vision were documenting Josh's mental weakness the whole time.

So with bay language showing he had no care in the world, just a happy-go-lucky fella ready to catch a z or two, he returned to the couch, sat down and stretched his arms up over his head. He yawned, batted the pillow Devlin had given him, flicked open the blanket and scooted underneath it, letting its warmth settle on him. As sleep began to settle on his eyelids, he went over the night again, removing all his suspicion and thinking only of the real things he saw with his own eyes and ignored his awful suppositions. Devlin had been decent. Decent but a dick. But that was his natural state. He was a dick to Rumble, and he was even sometimes a dick to Glenn, too. Maybe Devlin was just—

Josh's hand slipped under the sofa pillow to plump up his head's angle of recline and snagged a cord in the webbing between his little finger and ring finger. He had to lift his head to free his hand from whatever trap lay under the pillow. He withdrew a clump of fabric, and as he opened it, a warm and familiar fragrance swelled around him. It was a pair of women's panties; sexy flower-embroidered panties. They were a rosy pink, the side straps were doubled—two sexy lines of rosy cord sweeping over the hips on both sides, a spray of summer flowers framing the shape of the crotch.

SLEEPOVER 2

The apartment was quiet when Josh got home, five-to-seven in the morning, gray dawning light bathing his familiar space in glum reverie. Something was different. He recognized right away what was out of place. Kimmy had been home alone all night while he was out with Devlin, yet the apartment wasn't spotless, wasn't restored to orderly angles and uncluttered surfaces. Something about the incongruity with how he knew his beloved Kimmy to be twisted further at his heart. Not that coming home to find their apartment tidied would have resolved the torment he felt, only finding it untended further reinforced the dreadful chasm between him and Kimmy.

He kicked off his sneakers, walked into the living area, setting his overnight tote on the couch, and the zippered bag with his suit inside draped over the seat back. There were kernels of popcorn on the coffee table. The aroma of buttery popcorn remained.

As his eyes roamed down the hall toward their bedroom, his heart rate spiked and his palms went slick with sudden sweat. His stomach gurgled. He had to look away. But with his eyes on the popcorn kernels dirtying the tabletop, a surge of awful unfamiliarity frightened him enough an icy shiver whipped up his spine like a January wind. His eyes swelled in their sockets and he jabbed the back of his wrist into one, squeezing out a tear. He'd never been more bewildered in his life, more alone and frightened. Monstrous betrayal stormed at his mind's gates, battering it with blood-stained fists, scratching at his ramparts with ragged inch-long claws.

It took an entire minute with his hand clutched on his skull, palm on his nose, splayed fingertips pressing on his forehead and temples, before the anxious whorl of fight-or-flight subsided. He breathed deep, held it, and slowly let it go. Over and over.

When he had his mind in place again, he faced the hallway, arms hanging at his sides. The first step was the hardest, but then he was traveling, ears stuffed with imaginary cotton, the only sound he was privy to was the rapid beat of his heart. He paused at the bedroom door, open but parted only an inch, and fought the return of terrifying panic. When his hand went to the door, it shook.



Nothing prepared him for what he saw. His heart jumped and an audible gasp of shock whisked from his lips as he physically recoiled from the sight.

With only the sound of his thudding heart in his ears, his eyes narrowed as he struggled to make sense of what he saw. Two figures in his bed; two separate but side-by-side cotton mountain ranges under the terrain of the bedcovers.

Kimmy was in bed with someone.

His knees went to jelly, and his bladder loosened. He caught the surge in time before he urinated, lurching forward and gripping the door handle, his weight sagging against it.

The sleep-disturbing sound of his weight on the door hinges had one of the figures stirring. His jaw slackened, and his eyes quivered on the sight like a man awaiting some imminent biblical revelation. There were two heads on the pillows, the blankets pulled up high so only the crowns showed. Two heads of black hair. One head arose, looked over the other head to regard the table side clock. 6:59. It was Kimmy. The head rolled away from the other to look up at the ceiling—then she caught him watching in her periphery. Kimmy jolted but relief showed on her face almost immediately, and she rolled her eyes and chuckled as her head hit the pillow. When she lifted it again, the other head rose as well, turning his way, the two people in bed rising at the same time. It was like two Kimmys, and for one long-enduring schism, he stared and blinked without comprehending. Two Kimmys stared at him, both sleepy and mildly amused, one more sheepish than the other—embarrassed?—both with the same haircut, one in a Western law sweatshirt, the other in a Queens one. One face was sly and smirking, lean and mean, the other softer, paler, innocent.

Hyun. Jesus, it was fucking Hyun.

A tidal wave of emotion crashed against his embankment, and he hid his face in his hands. He'd come home early for a purpose and now he'd been sent into disarray, the fog of war encircling him and his wife disarming him. He breathed into his hands and opened his fingers to see Hyun jumping out of bed like he had caught her doing something, separating herself from Kimmy, pulling down the sweatshirt to cover her upper thighs. Was she not wearing anything under that sweatshirt?

Kimmy said, “Why are you home so early, baby?”

Josh’s eyes were glued to Hyun, who sat on the edge of the bed near the foot, looking at him without expression. His mouth opened to answer Kimmy, but no words came. All the things he wanted to say that had welled up in his throat, ready to be unleashed, were all quashed, sprayed down like revolutionaries under authoritarian water cannons.

His hand went in his pocket out of instinct. The hand hadn’t forgotten what he was here for. His fingers gripped the silk-satin embroidered panties he’d found in Devlin’s couch, working them like a worry-stone.

“Josh?”

“I— I couldn’t sleep.”

“You’ve been up all night?”

Kimmy rested on her elbows, sexy, hair bed-tossed. Why did Hyun look so guilty? Was it his imagination, or did Kimmy have her arm around Hyun?

“Pretty much,” he said, letting the panties go, rubbing that hand through his hair, feeling a sudden weight of leaden enervation settle on his shoulders, seeking to push him to the bedroom floor. Rage sizzled in his heart. Hurt whimpered on his tongue. All he’d come for this morning was dashed.

Hyun, in her soft voice, said, “We stayed up late watching Boys Over Flowers.”

He squinted, dizziness making the room sway. “What’s that?”

“A Korean show,” Kimmy said. “From when we were younger. You know it.”

“Oh.”

Kimmy said, “Hyun stayed over so we could all go out for brunch this morning.”

Hyun checked her watch, then didn’t know what to do when she wasn’t wearing one.

Kimmy sat up and opened the bed covers, showing off a long leg all the way to her hip. Wasn’t she wearing panties either? She said, “Come on, it’s too early to eat. Come to bed and sleep in with us.”

Hyun looked at Kimmy, chewing her lower lip. Kimmy encouraged Hyun to come back to bed, luring her with the sway of her smiling face, like pulling a fish onto a boat. Hyun looked at Josh and then back to Kimmy.

None of this was how it was supposed to go. Nothing was right. Everything was wrong. His hand went into his pocket and gripped the panties. Adrenalin rushed as he played with the idea of tossing them into Kimmy's face and saying she left them at her boyfriend's apartment. But the feeling abated. It was wrong to do it in front of Hyun. It would be cruel to Hyun. As much as it would hurt Kimmy more to do it in front of Hyun, it wasn't the right thing.

"I'm just going to lie on the couch," he said.

"No," Hyun said, rising, "I'll go to the couch."

He saw she wore PJ shorts. She'd borrowed the whole ensemble from Kimmy. He could still see them in his mind that way he'd first seen them coming into the bedroom, confused, like they were the same person—and yet diametrically opposed. One innocent, one sinful.

Kimmy said, "Oh, come on, both of you just get in bed, please, before I get too awake."

Hyun huddled in Kimmy's sweatshirt, unsure. Hyun's presence made this awkward and uncomfortable, and he cared about her. He trudged to the bedside—but Kimmy stopped him. "You didn't wear these clothes last night, did you?"

“No, just to drive home in.”

“Okay,” she said, satisfied, opening the sheets again for him to join her.

With Kimmy holding up the bedding, he backed into the bed wearing socks and sweats and a T-shirt. Kimmy let the bedding settle on him, saying to Hyun, “Come back to bed. A little more sleep, then we’ll go get some breakfast. I would kill for a mimosa this morning.”

Josh felt the bed jostle a little with Hyun’s slight weight joining them. Kimmy folded her arm around his neck, her mouth near his ear. “How was your night? Did you guys have fun?”

“Uh-huh.”

“How was the game?”

“Jays won.”

“That’s good. What was the box like?”

“Luxurious.”

Kimmy shifted, lifting her head a little. “You okay?”

“Yeah.”

“Everything okay with Devlin?”

“Why wouldn’t it be?”

“Did you guys go out after?”

“Yeah.”

Kimmy was quiet a while. Then she whispered, “Did you guys get in a fight or anything?”

“No. We’re cool.”

“Okay,” she said, and he liked the idea of her stewing over what was wrong. But it felt petty. He knew it was petty. There was so much more to this. Even in bed with her right now, all he could feel was a self-perpetuating cycle of sick torment. Knowing in his heart he was right, knowing the truth,

but still deep inside, praying—fucking praying—there was something he didn't see. If Kimmy's arm weren't around him right now, he'd be ungrounded, vulnerable, likely to fly off the face of the planet with the speed his world spun around him.

He said, "Thanks for sending that bag for me."

"You're welcome." She kissed the edge of his ear.

"You gave it to Devlin at work?"

"Yeah, why?"

"No reason."

"Did he do something with it?"

He shook his head no, but Kimmy was bothered. She lifted off him, and the cool air hitting the warmth transferred to his neck from her arm felt miserable. He reached up and found her arm and pulled it to return to his neck. She snuggled up to his back. His hand wandered down to the back of her thigh, to the leanness where her knee bent.

“I missed you last night,” she whispered.

“I missed you, too,” he said, thinking about how he found her in bed with someone else. In the last twenty-four hours he’d been shifted to a different plane in the multiverse, and in this one Josh was scared and lonely and full of despair. Nothing in his world was the way he’d thought it to be. He could still taste that fucking stupid expensive cigar and it made him want to hurl. Something sick and furry curled up in his esophagus, and for three terrifying seconds, he was convinced he would hurl. He even leaned closer to the bed’s edge so he wouldn’t have to do laundry today.

It didn’t come. Despite his horrible evening—the cigar, the drinking, the box nachos and charcuterie, the strippers, his wife’s panties at her boss’s apartment—the gorge didn’t rise, and he settled back into the bed with Kimmy. Her arm went around him again and hugged him. She smelled good. She smelled like his familiar best friend and lover. The room spun.

The hand on her knee retreated up to his own hip and into the pocket of his sweatpants. He fisted that lacy, light fabric—so heavy with existential weight—turned it over and over, squeezing and squeezing, wishing it were all so much easier.

He withdrew his hand and rolled to his back, Kimmy’s face over his, dark eyes watching him. “Go to sleep, Josh. It’s so early for a Saturday.”

His eyes stayed on hers, her pupils flicking over his, trying to decipher his mood. Blanket pushed down, he brought the balled panties to his chest and

let them lay there, studying his wife's eyes, watching her reaction, looking for anything sparking a glimmer of hope but knowing it wouldn't come.

Kimmy frowned at the clumped fabric that eased open, folds blooming and revealing the true colors of this bud as it became a loathsome flower.

He said, "Did you lose these?"

TIGER BITES

The wadded material on Josh's chest opened up to reveal familiar embroidered roses. They were her panties. On survival instinct she snatched them from his chest and hid them under the covers. Hyun was in their bed. But with the panties gone, there was nothing between them to hold their attention, and she looked into Josh's eyes as the bewilderment settled in.

"Did you lose these?"

In Josh's eyes she saw hurt; vile, whimpering hurt that reminded her of a beaten dog cowering before its abusive master. Her jaw slackened and dumbfoundedness dazzled around her like a merry-go-round. The longer their gazes stayed connected, the faster her heart beat; the more her pulse swelled her neck and blotted out her hearing.

All her deviousness, all her manipulations, her self-affirmed mastery, shattered around her like fragile porcelain. Josh had tossed evidence of her betrayal in her face and caught her flat-footed. And now that he'd struck her dumb, no believable defense could come to her lips that would save her. Guilt beamed from her face and nothing could stop it. All that came was the urge to burst into tears.

She looked down, dipping her chin. To Hyun, she said, “I think we should get up.”

It was like all the lies she needed to tell couldn’t have Hyun as an audience. Like what Josh might believe, Hyun wouldn’t.

Over her shoulder she saw Hyun regarding her. Hyun was ready to leave. Hyun didn’t want to be in their bed together with them, anyway. Five minutes ago Kimmy had been toying with the idea of plying Josh right away, tempting him with Hyun, oblivious to his discovery, pumping him how it must have been like a fantasy to come home to her and Hyun in bed together that way. That had been the plan. A nefarious plan to enjoin her husband in her wickedness. The last plan in her long line of strategic immoral victories.

Hyun whispered, “Okay,” and shuffled out of their bed.



In the hallway, Hyun slipped her shoes on, Kimmy and Josh leaning on walls.

Kimmy said, “Sorry, Hyun. We’ll do brunch next week. Are you free next week?” It didn’t matter. There would be no next week. Nothing was going to be the same once Hyun left the apartment.

Hyun said, “That sounds good. And no worries, I know you were up all night, Josh.”

Josh stood with his arms crossed tightly over his chest, hands wedged into his armpits, like he was trying to protect his heart. He nodded, his expression glum, bags under his eyes.

A hard lump sat in her throat, somewhere around her collar bones, making it difficult to swallow. Her temples throbbed. Hyun looked from Josh to Kimmy, and Kimmy struggled to find some convincing reason for Hyun to stay. Because if Hyun stayed, Josh couldn’t expose her for the disgusting villain she was. The longer she put it off, the longer it wasn’t true.

But it was true.

Hyun came close for a hug and Kimmy embraced her way too hard. “I had so much fun last night,” she said, her voice a constricted squeak. She sniffled, and her eyes swelled with wet.

Hyun stepped back, knowing something was wrong now, sure of it, her plump mouth condensing to a dollop and her eyes averting to the floor.

Josh said, “Say hi to Sophie.”

“I will—”

“Yeah, give her— give her a kiss from us,” Kimmy said, voice quavering, grasping at the ephemeral connection of family; feeling the sweetness of good times when she wasn’t a cheater, wasn’t a cruel betrayer. Regretting it, wishing she could take it all back.

“Okay, guys, I’ll see you,” Hyun said, flashing a timid wave, then stepping out of the apartment door. The second it closed, Kimmy’s shoulders raised to her ears in anticipation of an explosion from her husband. Either he would scream at her or, what she expected, he would collapse and break down in sobs and reject her consolation with flailing arms. A thousand times over she would prefer Josh scream at her over the latter. She didn’t think she could bear the latter.

But Josh did neither.

Instead, he turned his back to her and walked into the kitchen. She went to the apartment door, leaning on it, sliding the lock in place. She stared at the spot where Josh had been standing. It would be nice to remain in the hallway forever.

In the kitchen she found Josh standing with his back to her, one hand supporting his sleep-deprived weight on the counter, the other hand on his hip. She said nothing, standing and watching, waiting to see what he would do. He’d slept over at Devlin’s and Devlin had given him her panties. Josh had asked her if she’d given the bag to Devlin and she’d said she did; he’d cut her off from any defense. The asking of that question proved Josh knew exactly what kind of liar she was. What other way would her panties get in Devlin’s hands?

The question remained: why would Devlin give Josh her panties?

Josh cleared his throat, then spoke in a draggy monotone. “I can’t do this anymore, Kimmy.”

At last, hearing the words got her stomach fluttering. A swell of torment welled up inside her and she was on the verge of doing what she thought Josh would do: collapse in a sobbing heap. But all the bad she’d done, all the terrible things she’d done to this man she claimed she loved could never be made right by the shedding of tears. There was no scenario where he would come to comfort her, shush her and make the hurt go away. She deserved all of the pain she felt.

All the angst of her betrayal done in secret was nothing compared to the person she loved knowing she’d done it. And done it to them.

The betrayal was so meaningless, so arbitrary. What had she ever done it for?

Selfish, selfish, selfish.

“Do you hear me?”

“I hear you, Josh,” she said, surprised at how brittle her voice sounded.

“I’m in awe,” he said.

Her lips wriggled and squirmed as she struggled not to cry. She knuckled an eye, the wet of tears on her skin. No words came to her. For the whole summer, lies spilled from her tongue like spider silk. Now nothing.

Josh turned. He looked hollowed out and full of pain. His eyes met hers and she could see tears in them. “I’m in awe, but I can’t do it anymore. It hurts too much.”

She nodded, waiting, sniffing.

He said, “Okay?”

She nodded again.

Josh took a deep breath and let it out. It was shaky. He wiped his eyes. Then when it proved too much, he snatched a paper towel from the roll and blotted them. His shoulders shook.

She couldn’t stop the tears now, either.

Josh cleared his throat and looked to the kitchen ceiling. “I thought I wanted it, but I don’t.” He lowered his chin to face her. “I appreciate it—but that one was too much.”

She blinked and narrowed her eyes on him, for the first time thinking maybe she misunderstood this whole thing. “Okay,” she whispered, scalp tingling.

“When I found them, I thought it was real. I didn’t...”

“Thought what was real?”

He threw up his hands. “That you didn’t put them there. That I really found them.”

Put them where? Her ears thudded with her rapid pulse again as she struggled to comprehend.

“I’m in awe,” Josh continued. “In awe you would do that. Could do it. But I don’t want it. I know you think I do, but I don’t.”

She stepped closer, worried she misunderstood and that he would reject her. He didn’t push her back, but she stayed an arm’s length away—she didn’t

deserve to be close. Her eyes narrowed to hyper-focused slits, her hearing returned as all her senses sought to absorb any sliver of information that could save her life. The urge came to spin lies, but she wasn't even sure where she stood, where to aim. She existed on a wafer-thin sheet of ice.

Josh met her gaze. "You hid them where I would find them. I found them. But . . . But it wasn't exciting. It had been a weird night, and it was the last thing I needed."

"Josh," she said, ready to pronounce the truest thing she could. "I'm sorry. I'm really sorry."

"It's gone too far."

"I didn't . . . I never wanted any of this to hurt you."

"You did," he said, looking at the kitchen floor. "You did because I wanted it to hurt. I told you I liked it."

"Josh . . ."

"I blame myself."

“Don’t, Josh, that’s—”

His eyes met hers. “What did you do after you dropped Devlin off at his hotel room?”

Something unsettling flickered in his gaze. She said, “What— when?”

“At his hotel room in Cayman.”

Her mind raced a million miles an hour. What had Devlin told him? “After dinner?”

Josh’s gaze was hard. “Was there another time?”

“Yeah,” she said, defiant but timid. “From the lawyer’s office. I had that meeting.”

Josh’s hardness melted and his eyes drifted to the floor like someone had unplugged him. He folded his arms over his chest again and bent at the waist like his insides were aching.

“Josh, what did Devlin say to you?”

Josh made a sound of discomfort, not answering, only breathing. She called his name again.

“Devlin didn’t say anything.”

He panted now like he had stomach cramps, like in agonizing pain. The tears returned to her eyes and she couldn’t help herself: she reached to touch his face. Josh pulled his head away. “Josh . . .”

“I’m fine, I’m fine,” he said, upright again, wincing. He rubbed his brow, eyes closed. Panties. Something about Devlin in Cayman. She’d fucked Josh’s head up so much she’d broken him.

“Josh, whatever it is, it’s over,” she said, wishing this was the discussion of her infidelity and they could past it as easy as this, knowing somehow though that she’d got away with it again. But this time had been so close she’d scorched Josh, and now she saw the effect, she didn’t like it at all. “I won’t do any of it again.”

Josh’s arms fell to rest at his sides, shoulders slumped. He regarded her fully, expression blank, then stepping forward to cup his hands to the sides of her face. She couldn’t help flinching.

He said, “You’re mine.”

She blinked, sniffled, then overflowed with tears. “I’m yours,” she said, voice thick with emotion.

He let her face go and turned his back to her, heading out of the kitchen and down the hall to the bedroom. She stood alone in the kitchen for a very long time, staring out the windows in the living room, at the gray summer day, wondering what just happened. She looked to the fridge door, to the stove, like they were witnesses she needed to confer with to get their opinion.

Whatever had just happened, she’d come out alive. Josh didn’t know. She shook her head with disbelief, resisting the urge to chuckle. She bent over the counter, let her forehead touch the cool surface and rubbed her fingertips on her scalp. Unbelievable.

Then she was up and moving, opening the cupboards, drawing out items and putting them on the counter. She would bake lotus leaf bread, cut up the left over steak in the fridge, and make one of Josh’s favorites: Gua Bao, her grandmother’s recipe, buns with stewed meat inside; Tiger Bites Cow.

Gray day outside, a Saturday, maybe they could watch movies together and eat all day. Josh needed cheering up. He needed to be zapped back to life. They could play video games. Tonight they could order pizza. Maybe Meyer would come over. And Sophie. Steve. Oh, and Hyun. Hyun could come, too.

She dusted flour from her hands, wiped them on a tea towel and headed down the hall to the bedroom. Halfway there, she heard an unfamiliar

sound. She slowed, tuning her ears to the faint sound by cocking her head. A half dozen or more coughs, then three longer whisks. Some strange Morse code. By the time she made it to the bedroom door, she knew what it was. The door was closed but unlatched. She nudged it open.

Josh sat on the edge of the bed with his face buried in his hands. He was crying. No, sobbing. Trying to be quiet, not wanting to be overheard. The sight broke her heart. But the last thing she could do was to go to him. Anything she believed moments ago was untrue. Josh knew what she'd done. Those were the sobs of a man whose wife had done to him what she had done.

She backed away, feeling as unendingly empty as the yawning universe, a pin prick on the ocean's surface, a nothing in vast empty cold. In her cat basket room, she closed the door, no emotions yet, nothing on her face that would show the bear-trap realization that had just severed her relationship with a man she actually loved.

Around to the far side of her sewing table she slumped down, her back against the cold metal side of a filing cabinet. She couldn't breathe. Breath wouldn't come in. She sat wild-eyed, trying to draw in oxygen. Her chest had seized. She worked her mouth around, rolled to her side, elbow on the floor. At last, shaky, stertorous air chugged into her stiff chest. But now she hyperventilated. She crouched on the floor like prayer time, eyes wide as could be, staring at a joint in the laminate flooring and willing herself not to zip off the face of the planet and into the sun.

"Oh God, oh God," she murmured, arm reaching up, hand searching the sewing table for the cordless phone. She clutched it to her chest and lay on

her back, trying to quash the rising panic that had overwhelmed her. Deep breaths, deep breaths, deep breaths.

At last, though shaky and tentative, she thumb-dialed a number and put the phone to her ear.

Josh knew. He knew what she'd done. Beautiful, innocent Josh knew what she'd done.

Devlin answered.

She said, "I want— I w-want you to f-fucking die."

Devlin said, "Who is this?" Coy, condescending.

"It's over," she said. "You and me are over."

"Kimmy. What's this all about?"

"You know what it's about, you fucking asshole," she spat. "I'm calling to tell you it's over."

“Josh got home okay? He wasn’t here when I got up.”

“I told you. I fucking told you not to do it. Don’t hurt him.”

“I didn’t do a thing, Kimmy. I don’t even know what you’re talking about.”

“It’s over,” she said.

Devlin chuckled. “It’s not over, Kimmy. It really isn’t.”

“It’s over, Devlin.”

“Kimmy, Kimmy,” he sighed with manufactured patience, and she could picture him pinching the bridge of his nose. “Listen to me, okay: It isn’t over. Not over at all. In fact, this is where it gets good.”

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